

A woman with dark hair and dramatic eye makeup is lying down, wearing a black lace top. The lighting is moody, with a strong blue/cyan glow on her face and hair, and a warm, reddish-orange glow on her chest. The background is dark and textured.

THE *SCORCHING* EROTIC MURDER MYSTERY

A
KILLER
OF A
ONE NIGHT STAND

EPISODE THREE

BESTSELLING INDIE EROTICA AUTHOR

MAX SEBASTIAN



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About the Author

Max Sebastian has written more than 20 novels, and regularly tops the bestseller lists for steamy erotic fiction. He began writing erotica at Literotica.com nearly two decades ago, and broke into the wider world of publishing in 2011.

Since then, Max has become well-known for sensual, steamy adventures in which couples explore thrilling alternatives to monogamous relationships, on their way to a very raunchy happy ever after—including menage stories, wife-sharing, hotwives, cuckolding and partner-swapping in various forms.

Max lives in London, England, and loves to hear from readers. Visit his website at www.maxsebastian.net.

Some of Max's Other Books

Web: MaxSebastian.net

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A Killer of a One Night Stand

Episode Three

Max Sebastian

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Prologue

One of the ropes binding his wrists to the headboard was less than secure.

All the time she was fucking him, riding him like a stallion, using him as nothing more than her own personal sex toy, he'd had half his attention on this fact.

Slowly, steadily, he'd worked away at the rope, wriggling his wrist to loosen the binding further, all under the guise of thrashing about in response to her furious passion.

Unlike the poor saps who had fallen victim to her in the past, he knew what was going on. He knew what came next if he let this play out, if he let her do what she always did.

What did he expect to do if he got his hand free from its restraint? Overpower her? What were the chances that that would work? He might have an edge on her being a man, but she was fit, strong. Just because he was male and she was female did not guarantee anything.

All he could do was keep calm, continue to work on the rope while she fucked him, take his opportunity if it ever arose.

Focusing on the rope helped him keep his own climax away. He felt certain that if he came, that would be it: she would be finished with him. He had to leave a little left in the tank, he had to give her something to come back to.

He was fairly sure she came as she milked his raging hardness with that tight pussy of hers—the way her whole body shook, jiggling her large breasts, the fact he felt her trembling through his cock as she squeezed him inside her, the way she yelled victoriously as she slammed herself down on him.

And of course, the fact that she pulled herself up off him, knowing he hadn't yet come.

“Don’t go anywhere,” she’d joked before slipping away for a bathroom break.

She trusted that he wouldn’t go anywhere. Only, she didn’t know he was aware his time was limited if he simply lay back and waited for her.

So he waited until the door to the en suite clicked shut, and he slipped his hand out of its binding, before reaching over to free his other wrist.

He was sweating profusely as he worked on the knots, his heart thumping in his chest so loudly he wondered if she might come back out here to find out what was causing all the commotion.

The other wrist binding presented no problems, but leaning forward to get his ankle, he had some difficulties untwisting the rope. God, it was taking too long.

She’d come out of the bathroom and that would be it: she wouldn’t give him any leeway.

And he knew what had happened to the other men she’d been with.

It came as a huge relief to get the final rope off. His body ached as he hauled himself off the mattress, grabbing his clothes from the armchair. Trussed up for so long, his joints clicked in protest as he now tried to move them, tip-toeing towards the door. Each agonizing click terrified him, making him certain she’d know what was going on.

The only hope he had was that she wasn’t listening out for any danger, she wasn’t expecting him to escape. This had never happened to her before—none of the others had been wise to her ways prior to the fact.

Reaching the door, he clamped his hand around the cold brass handle and squeezed, praying that the mechanism didn’t squeak or click loudly. He had to consciously control his breathing, too, as he eased the thing down, the adrenaline flowing through his veins forcing him to suck in oxygen, which she would hear if he wasn’t careful.

A bead of sweat dripped down his forehead and plunged toward the carpeted floor.

There was a faint click as the door handle reached its full incline and the door cracked open, but thank God it was all well-oiled, all slickly engineered, quiet like a German automobile.

Then he was away, a ticking clock sounding in his head as he looked right, then left, trying to remember the layout of this floor, trying to recall whether he'd turned left into the room from the elevator, or right. The hallway looked much the same in either direction, with its understated yet luxurious green carpeting, the elegant pale paisley wallpaper, the doorways on either side with their simple brass number plaques.

Right, he decided, and turned left out into the hallway. Well, it was 50-50. The important thing was for him to move, quickly, away.

He felt a rush as he sprinted away from the room, careening around a corner and narrowly avoiding a small marble-topped side table bearing nothing but a lamp and an ornate ashtray. This was going to work, he was sure of it.

“Ben?”

Behind him, he heard her call his name.

She was coming.

He wiped the sweat from his brow, took a deep breath and pushed on. Where was the damn elevator? This floor was some kind of labyrinth winding around the building's central courtyards.

His paranoia started to feed into his head now, he was certain that she would be quicker than him in these hallways, that she was more nimble than him, more athletic.

He started trying a few of the doors around him, thinking that to hide might be the wiser strategy than simply to run. She would assume he'd been too fast for her, assume he'd found the stairs, or lucked out on an elevator being here on this floor.

But none of the doors would open, of course.

“Ben?”

God, she was close. Perhaps just around the corner. His chest was burning now, cramp stabbing him constantly in the side.

Then, like a miracle, one of the doors opened. He dashed inside the room, closing the door behind him. It had no bolt to slip across, just a locking mechanism in the electronic key card-operated access system.

It was too late to figure out how to lock the door: she was too close. She would hear him, she would know he was there, he would be trapped, under siege.

He stepped away from the door, went through to the bedroom, half wondering if someone else might be in this room—a guest, who had perhaps forgotten to lock their door. But there was no one else there. He perched on the edge of the bed, dropped his clothes beside him. Pulled on his boxer shorts, his black pants.

Let out a long, slow breath filled with relief.

And then he heard a key card being inserted into the door, the mechanism responding to the card, engaging, opening. The guest coming back to their room? His heart was in his throat, pumping, pounding.

“Ben, Ben, come out, come out wherever you are!”

It was her.

“Well, that was unexpected,” she said remarkably calmly, stepping forth into the room, the door clunking shut behind her.

He saw her, and cowered in the face of her beauty and power, slipping down off the bed, onto the floor.

She did look incredible, he couldn’t deny it. Perhaps if she did want one more time with him, he wouldn’t even object, even knowing that that would be it, and then she would be done with him.

“I’ve never known anyone to run before,” she smiled, loving the effect she had on him, the power she had over him. The way he respectfully looked away from her, though he couldn’t help sneaking glances as she walked slowly toward him, reaching under her dress to slip off her little black panties.

She approached him and stepped forward to stand directly above his thighs, presenting him with the awesome image of her full beauty.

“Hands,” she said, and he knew what she wanted. He would be a fool to resist now. A fool to try to escape.

Sitting there on the floor, up against the bed, he held up his arms to her in full surrender. She slipped her panties over his hands, and twisted and looped it to bind his wrists together, her underwear feeling slightly warm to the touch, if he wasn’t imagining it.

“You really are something different, aren’t you?” she said, and he actually smiled. Proud, somehow.

She leaned down, touched his face, caressing his cheek gently.

He lifted his gaze to her, smitten by her power, even though he knew what was coming. With a single hand, she eased his head back against the edge of the mattress tilted up to her.

“I don’t think I’ve met anyone quite like you before,” she said, her voice smooth, sultry.

God, he just wanted to worship her now, to Hell with the consequences.

“But you didn’t think you could get away from me, did you?” she ran her hands all over her body, teasing him, tempting him, taunting him.

Her fingers slipped over her bare pussy, tracing through her stunning flower, stirring the hunger inside him as she gently gyrated her hips, dancing to some unheard melody.

“You know they’re calling me the Black Widow now?” she said, leaning over again, touching his jaw, kissing his mouth. “You don’t escape from the Black Widow.”

She licked his lips, stroking his cheeks with warm affection. She took another half a step forward, right over him, and peeled the dress up her body, then up over her head and away, revealing her glorious figure, those gorgeous breasts.

“Will you serve the Black Widow?” she asked, turning her body slowly around, over him, so that he could wonder at her figure from behind, taking in the sensational curves of her back and her rounded rear.

“Yes, Miss, with all my heart,” he said with a reverence that was as genuine as reverence got.

Her hands swept over the smooth skin of her body with a quiet whisper, and then as she flexed her thighs to offer him a view of her red rosy pussy, she teased apart her buttocks to show him everything, those delicate petals glistening with her dew.

Slowly, she lowered herself onto his mouth, letting him lick her, slide his tongue through her soaking folds, tasting her exquisite nectar. A few moments later and she was pressing herself down on his hot mouth, but then unable to remain there comfortably, she turned to kneel on the edge of the bed, to support herself on all fours on the mattress but over his head, so that he could continue to service her with his eager mouth.

He had no thoughts of escape now. Only of pleasing her. Her underwear had fallen from his wrists, but he wasn't going anywhere.

She came again with her sweet pussy clamped to his mouth, riding his face this time as she shuddered and yelled out to the gods, drenching his cheeks, his chin, his lips.

When he at last rose from the floor, it seemed that her climax had been so forceful it simply left her dazed, unmoving, her cute behind tilted up for him.

Pants down around his ankles, he slid another condom onto his rock hard cock, and then glided inside her, so easily since she was so very wet. This time he had no intention of holding back. He gripped her hips and began to pound into her.

“You're no Black Widow,” he said, pushing her forward on the bed, climbing up himself, mounting her like a lion on his lioness, no longer subservient.

“How do you know? I might be.” She smiled as he held her, his hands sweeping down to enclose her breasts as he continued thrusting into her tight pussy.

“Said on the news she handcuffed her victims to her bed. And you’re too lousy at tying ropes to be the Black Widow.”

She whimpered, denying nothing as he kissed the back of her neck, breathing in her sweet fragrance.

“You liked it, though, didn’t you?” she laughed. “Being my slave? My victim?”

I’ve never met anyone as good as you.”

He shared her laughter, said: “Maybe I’d like it more if I knew it wasn’t just a one-off.”

She smiled, and turned on the bed, so that she lay on her back, gazing up at him.

She looked as though she’d never even considered the possibility of seeing this man again—but that now the prospect of seeing him regularly actually appealed to her.

“You know they’d fire us both if they found out,” she said. “They don’t look kindly on staff members dating.”

He laughed again, and slid back inside her. “They wouldn’t look too kindly on a junior sous chef sleeping with a maid during his coffee break, but here we are.”

“You don’t want to date me,” she said, holding onto him, wrestling him over so that she could climb on top—the position she favored, it seemed. “You’re going to be a top chef some day, open your own chain of restaurants. I’m just a hotel maid.”

“A maid in Claridge’s,” he said. “That’s not just any maid. You’ll probably own your own hotel some day.”

She smiled, but with irony. “You don’t want to date someone with a reputation like me.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Isn’t that why you wanted to come see me? You knew you’d have an easy lay.”

“Maybe I love your reputation. Maybe I like that you take what you want from the guys around here. Maybe I think it’s sexy.”

She raised an eyebrow, but continued to ride him. “You think it’s sexy that I fucked Olly Martinez in this very bed last week?”

“I don’t have a problem with it, if that’s what you mean.”

“You don’t have a problem that I gave Gary the Bellboy a blow-job in that bathroom over there?”

Oh God, the thought of her being such an insatiable slut, and in her black-and-white maid’s uniform, drove him wild.

When she felt his hardness throbbing inside her at the thought, it made her gasp.

“That turns you on?” she asked him. “My reputation turns you on?”

“Why do you think I wanted to come see you?”

“What are you saying, you think it’s hot that I see lots of guys?”

“Sure.”

“And if I wanted to continue seeing lots of guys? If we were dating?”

“Why should I have a problem with it? As long as you still wanted to see me as well.”

“Most men wouldn’t want me to see other guys.”

“I’m not most men.”

“No, you’re not. God, you’re so hard. So big. I don’t think I’ve ever been out with anyone more than two weeks in my life.”

“You want to try?”

She stopped for a moment, looked at him earnestly. “Okay,” she said. “But you’re serious about me seeing other guys if I want to?”

“Of course.” He felt himself throbbing and tingling at that, and she felt it too.

“That really does turn you on,” she marveled, resuming her slow riding on his hardness. “You’d probably like it if I see some other guy if I told you all about it, afterwards, right?”

“More than anything.”

She laughed, and then said: “Okay, but we’ve got to finish now, I’ve got to clean the rest of this floor before noon.”

She withdrew from him, but then turned and lowered herself back onto him, grabbing his calves as she took him inside her again, quickly starting up a vigorous rhythm on his pole.

Her breathing and her gasps grew in volume, until she was once again crying out.

“Oh... oh...”

He held onto her beautifully rounded buttocks, assisting her in bouncing on his shaft, feeling his orgasm finally on its way, so powerful nothing would be able to stop it.

She was screaming when it finally hit.

But then she continued to scream as he finished, as she pulled herself rapidly off him, as she leapt off the bed, stepping backwards toward the door, her eyes wide, her face pale, her mouth wide open as she split the air with that awful sound.

“What is it? What is it? What is it?” he yelled over and over, but then turned his head to peer in the direction she was looking.

Over in the dark corner of the room, in the shadows created by an unlit floor lamp, a man in a suit sat slumped in an armchair.

They'd never noticed him when they'd come in, so wrapped up in themselves and their explosive lust for each other. But he also hadn't stirred a single time while they'd been in there.

He looked at the man for a moment or two, not really reacting. Confused, more than anything, as to why the guy had just sat there in silence while these two hotel staff members had rushed in, and started fucking on the bed.

Then he noticed how gray the man's face was, how weirdly blue his lips were.

How sunken were his vacant eyes.

It took a few moments for him to realize that the man was dead.

One

"It doesn't say anything more yet. He was poisoned, they think."

"Poisoned? But she hasn't used poison before."

"Maybe it's not her."

"And it wasn't suicide? People must kill themselves in hotels all the time."

"The police are calling it murder, the story says. No evidence the poison was self-administered."

The pretty blonde shuddered. "Well. I'm sure more details will come out at some point. Come on, shall we? I'm really hungry, and the sooner we get this out of the way, the sooner you can take me to Busaba."

"Busaba?"

"Thai, darling. It's just round the corner. You'll love it."

He stood up to check around them yet again, making sure there was no one watching, no members of staff who might come and see what they were accessing through one of their computers.

As usual this time of night, the large Internet cafe on Tottenham Court Road was fairly empty, just some foreign students and a few tourists, it looked like.

Reassured, he sank back down on the chair next to Emma, who was using her laptop while he accessed news sites on the desktop PC in front of them. She was wearing a pair of black-rimmed glasses tonight, rather than the usual contact lenses. She looked very cute in them, quite the student. Jonah didn't even know she wore contacts until this evening—and in fact, wearing glasses wasn't something she normally did with her dates. He liked it.

“So, you have tomorrow night off, but then Saturday you're seeing Bethany

again,” she was saying. Jonah drew up the familiar sight of the No Strings website on the desktop so that they might try to access Julian Foster's account.

“Then Tuesday you're seeing Kaia, who's married but allowed to play, then the following Friday I have you down to see a couple.”

“A couple?”

“You want married women, right? Here's a married woman. Only, husband watches this time.”

“Right, of course. Like Bethany.”

“Like Bethany, but sex from the get-go. Speaking of, Bethany wants you to pick the venue this time. Where do you want to go?”

“Venue? Oh.”

“Never mind, I'll choose somewhere.”

It still felt odd arranging these dates with Emma, talking about dating other women while her coconut perfume surrounded him, making him desire her at the same time. He was seeing her regularly now, he was beginning to feel the kind of bond that people usually felt when they were an item with someone. But Emma wasn't that kind of girl. She didn't have relationships with guys, she was all about the fun. And she was only

continuing to be with him because she found it entertaining to set him up on dates and then hearing about them afterwards.

She leaned over the desk, looking at the desktop computer now, absently toying with a strand of her golden hair. She seemed so into this, so intent on being his personal assistant. But was he in danger of feeling too close to her? When she got bored of this game, she would just walk away, start seeing a string of other guys again instead.

Maybe she'd never stopped seeing other guys, on the nights she didn't see Jonah.

He hadn't ever faced asking.

"Does it work?" she asked.

"I mistyped the username. Just need to.... So wait, I have Sunday and Monday off, right?"

"And tonight, remember?" she said, and pushed out her behind as though reminding him she was there, a beautiful sexual creature with needs of her own.

He nodded, "Tonight I have to see Lily. Lily Foster."

Emma pouted, "What do you have to see her for? You can't just call her about that book?"

Jonah felt a little burst of warmth blooming inside his chest. Was she jealous?

That was unexpected. He tried to contain his hopes—probably, she was just put out because she'd planned to spend the evening with him herself. He probably should have told her his plans, but then she hadn't really told him hers.

He said: "I thought you were okay with all this. With me seeing other women."

"Of course I am," she said trying to seem bright and cheery. "I'm arranging more dates for you, aren't I?"

“But you don’t want me to see Lily again?”

She sniffed, “You just don’t need to see her again. Do you? She’s told you the important stuff. It’s not like she’ll stop talking to you if you don’t go round there every few days.”

Once he’d got the proper details typed in, and hit the button, they were into the No Strings website, in the first murder victim’s account. Jonah felt a surge of adrenaline.

“Oh-ho! We’re in.”

“Well we knew it would work, didn’t we?” Emma peered over her glasses at him. He felt like kissing her. “If it didn’t, Mulray would have just said so after the police took a look.”

“Okay... so here’s what I don’t get. You clearly don’t want me seeing Lily Foster, but you’re happy for me to sleep with anyone else?”

Emma blushed, and it only turned Jonah on. “I’m just saying you’ve already slept with her, you don’t need to again.”

“Who said I was planning on sleeping with her again?”

“If you weren’t thinking about it, you could’ve just met her for lunch some time.”

She had a point, of course. He could have just met Lily Foster for lunch. After one night with her, though, he was curious to see her again, as much of her as she would let him. Just being in her presence had somehow seemed so incredibly enlightening. She was such an alluring woman, and had such experience of the world in which he was now moving in order to track down his brother’s killer.

“You have me seeing Bethany again,” he said, trying to be patient, but also perhaps, under the surface, trying to get Emma to admit she was jealous, that she didn’t want him to see Lily again because she did feel something for him, more than just personal assistant-with-benefits. She did want him for herself. “That’s a second date, isn’t it?”

“That’s different,” Emma said. “Bethany has a husband.”

They both looked at each other, and Emma's cheeks flushed vigorously scarlet again. For a momentary pause, they both recognized that what she'd said was some kind of admission that she felt threatened by the older brunette.

"And we've pretty much ruled her out as a suspect, right?"

"But Bethany's so cute, and she's trying to do this for her husband. It's sweet, isn't it? She deserves someone nice for her first time..."

Jonah smiled, and felt a little tingle or two deep inside at the thought of Emma sending him out there to seduce the young wife whose husband was so keen to share.

"At least you still think I'm 'nice'," he joked, and placed a hand on the curve of her lower back, as though to reassure her that he was still thinking of her first and foremost.

She glanced quickly around, checking they were still a fair distance from the nearest potential witness. Then she tilted her hips, and leaned away from him to prop her head up with an elbow on the desk, in a manner that showed him more of her thigh, lifting that little skirt she was wearing.

"Of course I do," she said, smiling as he moved the hand from her lower back around the beguiling curve of her behind, and then under her skirt to feel the soft, irresistible heat of her bare flesh. "But the way you were after you saw Lily... anyone would think you had a schoolboy crush."

She tilted her hips further, allowing his hand to drift a little further and brush over the cotton covering her pussy. She closed her eyes and let out a quiet moan as the backs of his fingers touched her there, feeling how hot she already was between her thighs.

"And you don't like the idea of me having a crush on someone else?" he asked her quietly.

"A crush? No, only on me," she said, then gasped quietly as one of Jonah's fingers found its way under the edge of her underwear, to dip into the moist folds beneath.

She opened her eyes and gazed into his for a moment through those cute glasses of hers, and he felt real affection for her, in a way he'd never

expected during—

even after—their first date.

“Just let me see Lily again,” he said, “and I promise nothing will happen.”

Jonah slid his whole hand under the material of her panties, and then forcing out another sexy little gasp from her lips, slipped the entire length of his middle finger inside her tight wetness.

She held onto the desk as though she might fall, offering a beaming smile as she looked down to see his arm disappearing under her.

“Oh, you can do what you like with her, I don’t care,” she sighed. “Just remember that you owe me big time, Buster.”

Jonah poked his head briefly up above the level of the computer monitors, once again making sure they were a good distance from anybody else, and that nobody else was on their way over here.

Then he flashed her a wicked smile, “I don’t mind owing you,” he said, then sank to the floor, crawling on his hands and knees under the desk to kneel between her thighs.

“What are you doing?” she hissed, looking down at him, but she was smirking at his impudence.

He eased her hips closer to the edge of the seat, and parted her thighs, smelling the female arousal in the air along with her coconut fragrance, as her pink panties were revealed to him again.

“Call it a little down payment,” he said, kissing his way along the smoothness of her inner thighs, edging under her skirt even as she tried to smooth it down, as though to hide what was going on under the desk.

“Aren’t we supposed to be trying to look at Julian Foster’s account?”

He smiled, “I thought you were the expert at all that.”

She sighed melodramatically, but subtly shifted the angle of her hips slightly to open herself more to his advance. She wanted this, she wanted

it badly. Her panties were damp as he nudged up against them, breathing in her intoxicating scent.

She leaned over him to hide the fact that he was there underneath her, but perched on the edge of the chair to ensure he had full access.

“Okay,” she said, her matter-of-fact tone of voice attempting to sound as though she was perfectly calm doing nothing other than checking her email in the late evening at an Internet cafe, and that there wasn’t a fully grown man hiding under her desk with his head between her thighs, gently edging aside her underwear with his nose. “So I guess we need to look at his stats, right? So...”

Her pussy lips were glistening as he pulled aside her panties and planted little kisses around the smooth flesh just outside her sex.

For a moment, he just inhaled her bouquet, appreciating where he was and what he was being allowed to do.

“...Hmm...nothing in here for a while... a few years, actually...”

Jonah kissed her just above her clit, her light sprinkle of golden pubic hair tickling his nose. Then he ran the flat of his tongue up from the base of her pussy all the way through her slippery lips to its apex, drawing out a long, quite moan

from her as he did so.

“Jesus, we’re going to get caught!” she hissed, but she didn’t stop him.

“Just keep an eye out for trouble,” he smiled, cheekily wiggling his face between her thighs.

“I see trouble...” she breathed, “he’s between my legs...”

Jonah lapped at her sweet petals, adoring her tangy flavor and the way she responded to him, one hand on his head, her fingers gently teasing his hair as he licked her, even while she used the other to access the computer.

“You looking at the website?” he asked her among mouthfuls of her exquisite sex.

“Surprisingly well, considering all the distraction I’m getting,” she said, then moaned quietly as he sucked gently on her clit. “There’s no sign that Julian went on any actual dates for quite a while—you said his kid is, what, three now?”

“Something like that.”

“That might have been when he stopped.”

“You can actually tell that?” he asked, slipping a finger into her tightness, feeling just how wet she was.

“It’s in his stats.”

“What stats?”

She giggled, “You never looked at your stats page?”

“No. I don’t think I saw one of those.”

“God, you really are clueless about this. It tells everyone how experienced you are at this... and how good your dates think you were.”

Jonah looked up at her. “How good they think I was?”

She laughed, “It doesn’t show up on your profile until you’ve been on at least

ten dates—and you can’t tell who’s given you what rating. You never saw the stars under the username in the profiles you were looking at?”

He felt a little foolish. “I thought that was some kind of decoration.”

She playfully slapped the top of his head. “I gave you five stars, incidentally,”

she said. “A glowing reference.”

Jonah picked himself up, wiping his face with a sleeve as he got to his feet to look at the stats page on the computer screen. As he retook his seat, he saw that Julian had, indeed, not dated anyone for three years

through the site. He had a four-star rating from the time when he had been dating, it seemed.

He felt somewhat stupid for missing this whole aspect of the No Strings website.

“So was he using this site at all in the mean-time?” he asked.

Emma’s right hand had strayed onto his lap, finding as she expected that he was sitting there with a major hard-on.

“I guess the last log-in stat was probably caused by Mulray’s buddies doing what we’re doing now...” she said, her fingers working to undo Jonah’s fly, then free his fulsome shaft.

He gave her a warning glance, though there was still nobody close enough to tell what was going on. Emma looked back at him as though to say, it’s only fair, with what you just did to me.

He didn’t stop her, though. He didn’t stop her as she started pumping his cock there in public. He didn’t stop her as she leaned over and took him in her mouth for a few moments.

He didn’t stop her as she stood up, edged over between him and the desk, and sat down in his lap, engulfing his hardness inside her tight, hot pussy.

“Jesus,” he breathed in her ear.

“What?” she said with mock innocence as she started to stir her hips. “As far as anyone else knows, I’m just sitting in your lap showing you how to work this thing.”

“Okay,” he said, but the way she closed her eyes, the way she breathed so deeply as she rocked back and forth on his lap, made him fearful that anyone even glancing their way would know exactly what was going on.

“Here...”

She reached for the mouse, then clicked in the website menu on the word

“Messages”. It drew up the simple email-style messaging system used within the No Strings system for people to communicate with dates or

potential dates.

“What does it say?”

“Oh God you feel good... No, look. It’s Julian’s messages. He was sending messages to people right up until... October last year.”

“So right up until he was killed. But no dates?”

“Nope.”

She leaned back, looked down between her legs, and pulled up her skirt to watch his cock sinking into her.

“So what was he up to?”

Emma looked up at the computer again, but as her right hand settled on the mouse, her left remained between her legs, and he knew she was toying with her clit while she continued rocking on his cock.

“In this message...” she peered at the text on screen. Jonah could hardly focus on the entire computer, so distracted was he by the pretty blonde student fucking him in public. “He’s got a whole long list of questions... when did you first start seeing other people? How many times would you say you’ve taken someone home for sex in front of your husband... why do you think your husband enjoys it so much that you date other guys?”

“Interview questions?” Jonah asked, trying to sound like he was keeping up with what she was saying.

“I think so...” she said, but she was quietly whimpering now.

Jonah felt his climax coming, with little control over it with such a gorgeous girl in his lap, now bouncing her butt up and down to fuck him more forcefully, while helping herself to a quick orgasm with a finger or two between her legs.

“Oh... oh Jesus... Oh my God...”

And she was shaking, laughing about her wickedness even while the orgasm was flushing through her system. Giggling almost uncontrollably as Jonah let himself go and released his burning seed deep inside her.

It was a risky moment, as moments went, since the force of their combined orgasm temporarily let all other issues fall down the priority list, including their attempts to keep quiet and hidden.

When they opened their eyes to survey the damage, and potentially make a run for it if people had seen what they were doing, they were relieved to see no signs of anyone having noticed them.

And then Detective Inspector Mulray walked around the corner, heading directly to them.

“Shit, shit, shit...”

A real scramble as Emma pulled herself off him, and returned to her own seat, and they both attempted to straighten their clothes and look vaguely civilized.

“Detective,” Jonah said, in a louder-than-normal voice that attempted to distract.

“Fancy seeing you here.”

Smart in her usual suit, Mulray looked at the pair of them as though she were a teacher, and they were naughty children. “It’s one of your usual haunts,” she said. “I thought I’d find you here. Please tell me you were trying to hack into Julian Foster’s account from in here...”

He said: “There can’t be any harm if you guys have decided there’s nothing of concern in there. And anyway, the website’s supposed to be so well encrypted, how will anyone know where we’ve accessed it from?”

Mulray rolled her eyes, but she wasn’t going to argue. “I’ve been tasked with...”

she said, then stopped and noticed Emma sitting there, saying to her a polite,

“Hello.”

“Hi,” Emma smiled a little bashfully, no doubt certain that Mulray knew exactly what had just been going on.

“Oh, sorry, this is my friend Emma,” Jonah said. “She’s... well, she’s assisting me in this whole thing.”

The detective sighed, “Assisting you in the private investigation you’re not involved in because if you were, it would be at severe risk of perverting the cause of justice?”

“Something like that.”

“Nice to meet you, Emma,” Mulray said, and Jonah was a little surprised at how genuinely friendly her tone was. Perhaps he’d thought it would be more awkward, Mulray meeting one of his female friends, his close female friends.

Perhaps that was just his ego thinking.

The detective turned back to him. “So what have you guys found, anything?”

He said, “Julian Foster wasn’t dating anyone through this website, not for at least three years.”

“Okay. We know that. Our IT boys said that much.”

“But he was sending messages to people through the website—he was using it, right up until he died.”

“Okay, so what?”

“He was asking people about their experiences. Women.”

“And men,” Emma piped up. “There’s one here. Maybe he was writing another book.”

“Another book?” Mulray raised an eyebrow.

Jonah said, “He wrote a book, a while ago. It’s fiction, I think, but it might be based on the real experiences of people he and Lily met.”

“And what was it about?”

“Non-monogamous couples, men who share their wives, I think,” he said, wishing he’d read more of Nate’s copy than just the blurb. “I found a copy of the book on my brother’s bookshelf, and Julian Foster only distributed the books to people he met, apparently.”

Mulray gave a contemplative nod. “Is that so? So you think he was writing another book about... about men sharing their wives?”

“I don’t know, haven’t had much time to look at his messages.”

“But where does all this lead to?” the Detective asked.

Then Emma said, “Maybe Julian didn’t go out on a date with the killer, maybe he only met her for an interview, or something like that. To find out more for his new book.”

Mulray tilted her head, entertaining the theory. “I might have to talk to my colleagues about this. You said there’s already a book, he wrote one before?”

Jonah reached into the shoulder bag slung over his chair, and pulled out the copy of *The Watchers* he had been intending to show Lily. He handed it to Mulray, who checked out the cover before turning it over to examine the blurb.

“You think I might take this copy?” she said.

Jonah was about to refuse, but then realized if he needed to talk to Lily about the book, there were half a dozen on Julian’s bookshelf in his home office.

“Sure,” he said.

“I think if I have to tell my colleagues about these messages in Julian’s account,”

Mulray said, looking at both of them, “I’ll say it was me looking at them. You know, so you guys avoid jail time.”

“Thank you,” Emma smiled at her.

“So if anyone asks...” the Detective added.

Jonah nodded, “We’ll deny any knowledge.”

Mulray sighed, but seemed happy. “Good,” she said. “I’ve been tasked with liaising with Martin Sallow’s next of kin,” she said. “I thought I’d see if you wanted to... you know, come along.”

Jonah felt a little crushed. If there was a chance of talking to relatives of another victim, he needed to be there. But he’d also promised Lily that he’d swing by her place that evening.

Well, if Mulray was now officially liaising with Martin Sallow’s family, there would be opportunities in the future, wouldn’t there?

“He’s visiting a certain Lily Foster this evening,” Emma said, allowing her disapproval to leach out into her tone of voice.

“Is that right?” Mulray said, nodding, looking from Emma to Jonah and back again as though trying to work out their relationship, whether Emma knew Jonah had slept with Lily, and perhaps for that matter whether Emma was sleeping with Jonah.

“I was going to ask her how my brother might have got hold of Julian’s book,”

he said.

“I’m sure she’ll be pleased to see you again,” Mulray said, and he couldn’t tell if she was taunting Emma, or commiserating with her. “I guess you’ll have to come with me another time to see Martin Sallow’s sister.”

“His sister?”

She shrugged, “His parents are both dead. No wife. Sister’s technically next of kin. She was quite close to her brother, apparently. Probably very useful to talk to.”

Jonah sighed, “I promised her I’d go over there tonight.”

Then Emma said, “Do you know anything about the latest one, Detective? The latest victim?”

“Not much more than the details they’ve made public already. He was a City

boy, a trader, just like your brother. Similar age. Single, might have taken the occasional hit of cocaine, but nothing particularly unusual for those kind of guys.

Mostly picked women up in bars—that’s what my colleagues are going on at the moment.”

“They think he picked the killer up in a bar?” Emma asked.

“They’re beginning to think the killer picked up all her victims in bars.”

“Even Lord Moss?” Jonah asked.

“Well, you know he’s not officially part of this case.”

Jonah sniffed. He felt a little stunned. He could just call Lily and tell her he’d see her another night. Really, he should have done. But in truth, he had been looking forward to seeing her again.

“Well, hey,” the Detective said, absently batting her hand on the back of one of the empty chairs standing next to her under a desk, “do you want to come with me instead, Emma? I mean, if you are helping him with his little... research project.”

Emma was somewhat taken aback by Mulray’s suggestion, but now looked up at Jonah, her expression clearly indicating a belief that this could work, this might be useful to them.

“I don’t see why not,” she said.

“Sure,” Jonah nodded. And why not? Emma was more than capable. She knew enough about the investigation now to ask useful questions, if she was given the opportunity with Martin Sallow’s sister. “I think that would be a great idea,” he said.

“Excellent. Then it’s decided,” Mulray nodded, and said to Emma, “We have to go to a pub near the City. The Queen of Hoxton.”

“Shoreditch?”

“That’s the one.” She turned to Jonah, “You’re welcome to come along after you’ve met with Lily, of course...”

“I’ll see how late it gets,” he said.

Mulray smiled. “Okay, let’s go,” she said to Emma, and then gestured to something lying under the desk. “You might want to bring your... your underwear. The air conditioning’s a little overzealous in my car at the moment...”

The Detective turned to leave, and Jonah and Emma saw to their consternation that indeed, Emma’s panties were lying there underneath the desk, a dead giveaway for what had been going on before Mulray’s arrival.

Two

As he climbed the steps to Lily’s front door, he felt the depressing sense that this was a mistake.

He did need to speak to her about finding Julian’s book among Nate’s possessions—and perhaps about their recent discovery in Julian’s website account that he probably wasn’t cheating on his wife in the months leading up to his death.

But perhaps he should have just called her, spoken to her on the phone. Perhaps Emma had been right.

Traipsing along to that same street, Stanlake Road, in the same gloomy part of Shepherd’s Bush seemed like a long way to go just for a conversation. Perhaps Emma was right to fear he had ulterior motives—he couldn’t deny he was drawn to Lily Foster. She was so fascinating, so beautiful in a way that wasn’t entirely definable.

He didn’t have an interest in pursuing a relationship with her, though. He was sure about that. He didn’t feel about her the same way he felt about Emma. It was just a crush, a sexual attraction that had not been fully quenched just yet.

As he reached for the doorbell, Jonah felt the kind of fluttering in his belly that suggested he really did hope she might be in the mood to

seduce him—and yet a big part of him wanted to avoid that at all costs if there was the possibility that it would hurt Emma.

Before he pressed the button, he paused briefly, turning his head this way and that to peer down the street, checking for watchers. Was Mulray or one of her police colleagues sitting in one of these darkened cars parked alongside the road? He couldn't see anything, it was too dark, there were too many shadows.

Jonah pushed away his paranoia and pressed the button. His heart jumped a beat or two as he heard a door close somewhere in the flat, and the unmistakable

sound of someone approaching.

“Jonah! There you are!”

She looked stunning, and somehow perkier than the last time she'd opened her door for him.

“In the flesh,” he smiled. “I'm sorry, I could have just called...”

“No, it's fine. I mean, I'm pleased to see you again,” she was positively beaming, giving Jonah the faint impression that she was mildly shocked he was back, that perhaps she expected any ordinary man to have screwed her and left, never to return. “Come in, come in.”

He felt a tingle of excitement as he stepped inside, and breathed in a chestful of her Chanel No.5 as she politely kissed his cheek. The scent evoked such strong memories of their last time together that Jonah found himself reaching up to touch her face as she kissed his other cheek, and suddenly he was pulling her to him, his lips touching down on hers.

He heard her catch her breath, felt her hesitate, but then she was melting into him, her sweet lips sliding over his, and she was kissing his mouth as forcefully as he was kissing hers.

He noticed she was wearing lipstick—it was a fairly subtle color, but it felt waxy as he gently sucked on her lips. In fact, she was properly made-up, with impeccable eyeliner and mascara, her reddish-brown hair loose but apparently brushed and perfectly presentable.

Had she been expecting something to happen with him?

They broke apart as Lily remembered to close the front door, offering him a nervous giggle as she did so—oops. If anyone was watching, they'd just given them a show that would confirm a few things.

"I didn't think you'd want to see me again," Lily said in a breathless whisper.

"Why? We had fun."

"We certainly did. I just thought... you know, damaged goods and all that."

"Damaged goods? You've got to be kidding."

He pulled her by the waist towards him again for another kiss, too tempted by her sophisticated beauty. Yet strangely, it made him feel a hint of bleakness inside. Guilt. Emma would not want this.

As he kissed her this second time, he allowed his hand to slip down her back to pull her firmly to him, and for the first time really noticed the silky texture of a dress that was not designed for a night in.

"You look nice," he said, eyes dipping down to check the low neck-line of her little black dress, taking in how it displayed her fulsome breasts to perfection, just a hint of purple lace from her bra underneath.

"Oh God!" she gave a little gasp. "I have a date. Wait—maybe I can still call him, cancel—"

"You have a date?"

Jonah felt a funny little twinge inside. Why should he object? He wasn't dating her. He'd slept with her once. He shouldn't feel any kind of jealousy.

Lily gently pulled away from him, and he followed her down the hallway to the kitchen. No sign of her kid—but then if she'd arranged to have a date, no doubt he'd be with the grandmother again.

“When you called, I completely forgot about my date. Then when I remembered... I don’t know. I suppose part of me thought maybe you wouldn’t show up... or maybe you’d just want to ask me a couple of things on the doorstep...”

“It’s okay,” he said, though he felt flushed, he felt hollow inside. He had expected more with Lily, deep down. Maybe not anything romantic, but probably more than he’d want to admit to Emma.

God, this was so complicated. He really liked Emma, he didn’t want to disappoint her.

“I don’t have to stay long,” he told Lily.

There was a laptop sitting on the kitchen table, looking strangely high-tech for this luddite household.

“You got yourself a computer.”

“I started using that website again,” she said. “I don’t think it’s quite the same as when Julian and I used it back in the day...” She smiled bashfully as she took a seat in front of it. “I guess you kind of inspired me,” she said. “Made me see I need to start connecting with people again.”

“Hence the date,” he said, feeling pleased he had had such a positive effect on her.

She was gently blushing as she said: “I really didn’t think you’d want to see me again.”

He came round to see what she was up to on the laptop, and she dragged a chair out from under the table for him. Lily’s new profile went by the name of Rachel360. Well, it made Jonah feel better about using a fake name in his own profile—he guessed it was fairly common.

“I suppose I jumped the gun a little,” she said, as he watched her typing an apology into the message box on the website, directed at someone named

‘Jason342’. “You just got me so fired up... I couldn’t stop thinking about it. I needed more.”

Jonah shared her smile. He said: “Hey, it’s okay. You don’t have to do that. I think it’s good you’re dating again. We had some fun, that’s all.”

“I don’t want you to think ill of me,” she said. “I suppose... I’m just not cut out for monogamy any more...”

“Me neither,” he stroked her hair, and she seemed to lean in to his touch. “What time were you due to meet him?”

She glanced at her watch. “We’re supposed to meet at that pub I took you to, in about half an hour.”

“You think he has a smartphone?”

“I’ve no idea.”

“If you’re meeting in half an hour, chances are he’s en route—if he doesn’t have a smartphone, there’s no way he can check this site for his messages.”

“No, I suppose not,” Lily groaned quietly. “God, I’m a heartless witch.”

Jonah smiled. “You don’t have to cancel your date.”

“But I don’t want you to go.”

“We can do this another—”

“Stay here tonight.” She leaned into him for another kiss, and as he breathed her in and indulged in the sweetness of her mouth, his tongue dancing with hers, he knew he wanted nothing more than to spend time with her. His hand touched down on her thigh, and he felt his cock thickening further at the sexy texture of her pantyhose and the underlying heat of her flesh.

But still, his conscience held him back. The thought of Emma.

Actually, her date was probably a godsend. His body was making assumptions about feeling more romantic about Lily than he should after a single night together. It was the kind of mistake he used to make as a teenager, inexperienced in the ways of women, feeling that just because one of them slept with him, he must somehow be in love. But here she

was, telling him she wasn't that kind of woman anyway. After what had happened with her husband, she wasn't someone who could be pinned down by a single man.

As he thought about it, that fact seemed only to make Lily Foster seem all the more alluring, all the more desirable. He wanted her to be free to enjoy other men. For other men to see what an incredible woman she was.

He was also curious, since he did have a hint of feelings for Lily beyond purely the physical, how it might feel to know she was dating another man now.

He might see how it would feel if the same were to happen with Emma. Or some other woman he did actually fall for.

It wasn't just fascination any more, after thinking seriously about what Julian

had done with his wife, and the kind of relationships he'd brushed by during his dating activities—Becky, Jessica, Bethany—he had started having the fantasy, of being the husband of a shared wife.

"I told DI Mulray about using that website with Julian," Lily said when they parted again.

"Feel better about it?"

She nodded. "It's not good to hide things away, is it? Makes you feel all nervous the whole time."

"You're not worried about it leaking out?"

"I trust her." Lily said, finishing up her message to her evening's date before hitting the submit button. "She can tell her colleagues any facts that might help the investigation—everything I did, that's not important. The important thing is who Julian might have met in those last few weeks or months."

She closed the lid of the laptop. Jonah said: "I've seen Julian's account on that website. I accessed it earlier this evening."

Lily nodded, her face looking dark. “So it worked then, his password? I suppose I could have looked at it myself.”

“He wasn’t dating the women he was seeing, Lily,” Jonah said, feeling suddenly sorry for Julian Foster, that his widow might feel poison for him, rather than proper grief, because she felt he’d betrayed her.

“He wasn’t dating them?”

“I saw his messages to them. Their responses. He wanted to interview them, to hear their experiences. I think he was writing another book.”

“Another one?” she seemed genuinely surprised. Her body seemed to slump, as though she was an inflatable doll and someone had just pulled out the stopper.

“But the last one hardly covered his printing costs...”

“Maybe he discovered the digital revolution,” Jonah said. “It’s all ebooks now, isn’t it? No costs to produce those...”

She looked up at him, and suddenly seemed bright again, her energy returning, her cheeks slightly flushed. “He wasn’t sleeping with them, you know that for a fact?”

“I’m pretty sure.”

She nodded, slowly, and then let out a long, deep breath. Relief, that was what it was. Pure, unadulterated relief.

And yet, she had that middle class English compulsion to hide her feelings.

“I’m sorry—I should have asked if you want a drink or something?” she said.

“Oh, I’m okay.”

“Are you sure? I’m having one.”

She retrieved a half-full bottle of red Bordeaux from the kitchen counter, and from a cupboard retrieved two glasses before Jonah even had a

chance to consent. “I always did need a little fortifying before meeting new people.”

He saw her nervously checking her watch, before handing him his glass of wine.

“Julian would approve, wouldn’t he? That you’re dating again,” Jonah said.

He took a big sip of the wine, feeling a little in need of fortifying himself. He’d underestimated how it would affect him to see Lily again. How strong a bond could form after a single night together.

“Yes, I think he would,” she said, and her tone of voice somehow indicated pride, a renewed appreciation for her departed husband, and what a special man he had been. It made Jonah feel better, somehow.

Lily was looking at her website account again.

“He’s not going to pick up his messages, is he?” she sighed. “I can just go there, and tell him I can’t stay.”

“What if he’s a nice guy?” Jonah chuckled, then raised an eyebrow, “Or a hot guy?”

“You should have seen his profile,” she flashed her eyes suggestively.

“Go on your date, have fun,” he said. “I insist. It doesn’t mean we can’t still be friends.”

She kissed him again, and this time her hand traveled to his crotch, slipping over his bulge. “With benefits?”

“Maybe,” he said, but felt that guilt eating away at his insides. He had to refrain.

“Stay here for me. Tonight,” she said, flashing him a mischievous grin before slurping her wine. “You know, it’ll be pretty hot knowing you’re back here waiting for me.”

“And if you want to bring him back here?”

She shrugged, “Aren’t you curious?”

“Curious?” Jonah felt his ears burn, suspecting that she could read his mind, that he did have that little spark of curiosity as to what it might have been like for Julian to watch this exquisite creature with another man. What he might feel if Emma resumed her use of the No Strings website, since he himself was continuing to see other women.

“I can see it in your eyes,” Lily said. “You want to know what it’s like, don’t you? To experience your woman being taken by another man.”

Jonah shrugged, “It’s difficult not to be curious about something like that.”



“You won’t get too jealous?”

“I’ll try not to.”

It did feel strange to say goodbye on the doorstep, with Jonah the one staying behind this time in the little terraced apartment on Stanlake Road, and Lily Foster the one venturing out into the dark night.

After the Bordeaux was finished up, she’d left him with the television and a nice bottle of red, a smooth 2002 Rioja.

He actually felt mild anxiety as he let her walk away down the street. Should he have accompanied her to the pub? Was he being impolite as a gentleman to simply leave her to it?

It was only a five minute walk down to the Crown. She’d be fine. Yet Jonah knew it wasn’t fears for her safety that gave him the slightly queasy feeling in his stomach. It was the fact that Lily was going out to see another man.

And those feelings were confusing. Was it purely because he’d slept with her?

Or because it reminded him that there was nothing to stop Emma going out there and seeing other men—they were hardly exclusive, with what Jonah was doing.

Perhaps Emma had been right to have doubts about his seeing Lily again.

Perhaps he'd made a mistake coming here. If he was getting jealous already, and she'd only been gone a matter of minutes...

And yet, he felt a quiver of excitement. He was going to deal with this, he was going to experience it. The strange pleasure-pain dichotomy of actually feeling something for a woman who was going out there to see another man.

Jonah heaved a sigh, and switched off the television. He couldn't focus on the gray, turbulent lives of the characters living around Albert Square. His head was churning too much. He found himself climbing the stairs, almost on autopilot on the way up to Julian's office from the half-thought that if he spent a little more time, he might actually find some clue he'd missed the first time.

Lily wouldn't mind, would she? She had let him take a gander at Julian's things

before, after all.

As he looked, that feeling of jealousy was not going away. Was this how Julian felt when he allowed other men to have sex with his wife? This cold feeling of pressure in his chest, the anxiety, knowing that some other guy was making her smile, making her laugh. That later, he might be making her moan and making her come?

He had to block it all out, Jonah knew that. Otherwise he'd go crazy.

Papers, papers, everywhere. It was hard to focus on paperwork when the heart was being squeezed.

Sifting through the papers on Julian's desk, they seemed to be in exactly the same state as when he'd left them. Jonah sighed—he wasn't cut out to be a detective. How did those amateur sleuths on TV get anywhere? This was needle-in-haystack stuff. In reality, you needed a legion of police officers and crime scene investigators to uncover anything.

He sat back, his eyes turning to Julian's bookshelf again, but his thoughts kept returning to Lily.

Looking among the biographies filling Julian's bookshelves, it seemed a little more obvious that many of the featured celebrities took a less-than-conventional approach to monogamy.

Mick Jagger with his two marriages and multitude of high-profile flings; President Bill Clinton with his major fall from grace; Ingrid Bergman with three marriages and three divorces; Prince Charles and his long-standing relationship with another man's wife. Jonah now saw titles dotted around the shelves featuring famous and infamous people who had experienced similar complex romantic relationships. Hugh Hefner, Elizabeth Taylor, Charlie Sheen, Warren Buffet.

His eyes came to the bottom shelf, which was packed full of box files. Grabbing one at random, he found it containing various papers—newspaper clippings, printed articles pulled from the Internet, photocopies of various documents and passages from books. It looked as though each box file contained the details of a single well-known person.

Jonah sat down on the floor and started pulling out files. He wasn't entirely sure why, but he was intrigued. A proportion of the people featured in the box files were dead, recently deceased. Most of them, however, were very much alive.

These were people Julian had written obituaries for—whether to be immediately published or saved on the newspaper database for the moment when they did die.

Some of the box files contained material about more than one person, it depended on how interesting they were. But what Jonah found surprising was that in many cases there were interview transcripts torn from a reporter's notebook. Julian had met some of the people he'd written about.

How odd must it have been to be a celebrity, and have a journalist want to come interview you to put together your obituary?

When he pulled out a box file to find it containing newspaper articles about a financier-turned-peer, newly appointed to Her Majesty's

government as a junior treasury minister, Jonah's heart leapt.

Julian Foster had written an obituary for Lord Moss.

Surely that couldn't merely be a coincidence? There were only newspaper clippings and a couple of photocopied articles about the guy, no actual interview.

But if the police had taken these files to examine, they would have kept something as potentially important as interview transcripts, wouldn't they?

Jonah felt the possibilities coming together—that Julian Foster might have met Lord Moss at some stage, to interview him for the purposes of putting together the database entry for his obituary, whenever it was needed.

The newspaper clippings were not particularly enlightening, or at least no more so than what Jonah had already read about Lord Moss. Douglas Moss was a city trader done good—over the course of a 30-year career he had risen from the trading room floor of Goldman Sachs to lead a renowned private equity investment group that had total assets of more than £3bn before he had stepped out for a ticket into the world of politics. His company had even owned a majority stake in one of the major UK power companies.

In his early 50s, he began to focus more of his energies on politics and his close ties to the Conservative Party. He'd been to school with the Prime Minister and a few other senior Tories, so his route into Westminster was destined to be an easy

one.

With his connections and his background, a peerage had been easily bestowed to get him in the House of Lords—and appointed as a government minister without having to worry about the complications of being elected to the House of Commons.

As a junior treasury minister, Lord Moss was suddenly influential on the other side of the regulatory fence in the finance sector. Rumors circulated that he had investment interests, hidden through various offshore vehicles, which could benefit from his role as a government minister. He

had always denied such rumors, and one of the articles in Julian's file detailed his latest denial.

He had been a somewhat controversial figure, particularly hated by anti-establishment types and anti-poverty activists. The Occupy movement, for example.

And being a major investment chief, he must have trodden on a few toes in his time.

There were plenty of people out there that might have motive to kill Lord Moss.

Was it simple coincidence that it had happened in a hotel, in such similar circumstances to the other Hotel Killings?

Jonah sighed. Surely Julian Foster's interest in him was more than just a coincidence?

Sitting there, thinking, Jonah's gaze fell on the corner of the bookshelf where the handful of Julian's novel sat. "The Watchers".

He felt stupid for not asking Lily about Nate's copy. That had been the main reason for coming here.

Jonah reached for the nearest copy, which appeared to be pulled out slightly compared to the other five copies on the bookshelf. There was no author's picture anywhere on the cover, inside or outside. The paper seemed thicker than the usual trade paperback you might pick up in a bookstore.

His eyes skirted through the blurb on the back cover once again, offering brief details on three couples whose lives—and love lives—ultimately intersect.

He knew he ought to read it, there could be clues inside. It might be difficult to concentrate on anything with so many thoughts whirling around inside his head, though.

Jonah wandered slowly downstairs again. What had Lily imagined he'd do with himself while she was out on her date? Watch television?

Returning to the safety of the front room and the couch in front of the television, he opened the book. It was divided into three volumes, each apparently detailing the experiences of a different couple. And of course, each couple was involved in breaking the rules of monogamy, with two of them engaged in wife-sharing, and the third involved in all kinds of partner-swapping and hijinks.

Dipping into the first part of the book, he was given the strong impression that the story was based on Julian's experiences with Lily.

Jonah was just getting toward the end of that first volume of the book when he heard muffled voices outside the front door of the house, and a key scratching around the lock before being fully inserted. How long had he been reading? He wasn't the quickest reader by any measurement, but he'd completely lost track of time.

Lily was back from her date.



He turned up the volume of the television as he heard the front door open and close. He wanted to make it appear that he'd been watching it while she was gone, rather than sifting through her husband's office without permission.

The pages of the novel on his lap flicked over to return to their natural position, leaving him holding the book open at the copyright information page. The copyright was from three years previously.

Julian had been writing this book just before his son had come along, at the peak of his wife-sharing explorations with Lily.

Presumably that was when he'd distributed the book, back when he and Lily had been active in the scene.

So, had Nate met Julian all that time ago? Had Nate been seeing married women as far back as that? Of course, there was the possibility that Nate had been given the book by someone else, someone who had been with Julian three years back.

But that didn't seem likely, somehow. Maybe while Julian was interviewing people for his second book, he was attempting to sell them the first. Had Julian been interviewing Nate for his next project?

Jonah glanced at the TV, saw the ten o'clock news was just getting started. The first item was about the situation in the Gaza Strip. Ten o'clock. He'd been there a good couple of hours. He often had lost track of time when he'd been reading.

He returned his focus to the book in his hands.

If Nate had been interviewed by Julian, his details might be available from Julian's No Strings account. That was a promising lead. And if they weren't, perhaps it signaled that Nate could only have come into contact with Julian Foster three years ago, during actual active non-monogamous adventures.

Lily had said that she'd never met Nate, hadn't she?

Perhaps she'd slept with so many different people—men and women—that she lost track, forgot who she had and hadn't seen.

A short clip showing the red-brick front of a hotel, complete with doorman and international flags flying over the entrance, caught Jonah's interest. The TV

camera zoomed in sufficiently to reveal it as Claridge's.

He turned up the volume.

"...has been named as Oliver Pearson, a stockbroker at a firm in the City, who lived in Islington..."

A photograph of a smiling tanned guy wearing a smart gray suit came up on screen—a wedding shot. He was married? That wasn't quite the same as Nate and Martin Sallow's profiles. Might not have stopped him from dating other married women, though.

He heard muffled voices from the kitchen, distracting him from his musings. He turned the volume on the television down again. Clearly one of the voices belonged to Lily. The other was male, almost certainly. She'd brought her date back, then?

Did she really intend to sleep with the guy, with Jonah waiting for her in the same house?

He heard Lily laughing, and for a moment felt his stomach sink. The date must have gone well—not only was she still with him, she’d invited him back here, rather than to a hotel.

“You want to know what it’s like, don’t you?” she’d said earlier. “To experience your woman being taken by another man?”

Sitting there now, Jonah felt himself getting hard, quite rapidly. But he also felt horrified, somehow, at what was going on.

He might be a little confused at how he felt about Lily, particularly considering how he felt about Emma, but what would it be like to know she was just upstairs, sleeping with another man?

“I think my husband might be home soon,” came Lily’s voice, much closer than before.

“And he knows all about this?” The man, Jason.

“Oh, of course.”

Their voices moved past the door, and then Jonah heard the clomp-clomp-clomp of the pair climbing the stairs, no doubt heading for the bedroom.

His heart seemed to leap into a higher gear. His erection reached full mast.

Lily was going to fuck another guy, right under his nose.

“Maybe he’ll join us a little later,” he heard Lily from towards the top of the staircase.

Jesus. Was she role playing with this date of hers? Pretending to be married, that Jonah was her husband?

Acid burned in his stomach. Hurt. A little anger, even. At himself for being so stupidly curious, for getting entangled in Lily Foster’s games. For feeling she might mean more to him than just a one night stand. He also felt a touch of anger toward Lily, for tempting him in the first place,

for bewitching him with her fascinating and seductive approach to sex. For tempting him to do things of which Emma would not approve.

Oh God, but he did feel aroused. To think he might hear her being pleased by another man. Or that he might even see it.

That he might have the kind of experience that had stirred his imagination ever since he'd first found out about husbands who allowed their wives to roam free.

It also excited him to think that this experience could open his mind to pursuing this arrangement in the future. Or that it would push him to start encouraging Emma to see other men while continuing to date him.

Was this how it had been for Julian?

Jonah was in two minds. He wanted to stay and talk to Lily about the book, about why Nate might have a copy of her husband's book. He also wanted, desperately, it seemed, to experience her debauchery, to feel how it might be to share a wife, to actually feel something for a woman who is free to see as many other men as she likes. But he also knew full well that Emma had been uncomfortable with him coming back to see Lily, that she almost certainly didn't want him sleeping with her again.

Emma was jealous of how he felt about Lily. To stay and sleep with the sultry brunette would be to betray Emma.

He pulled himself up to his feet. He could just walk out of there, hit the streets.

Grab a taxi and ask for the Queen of Hoxton. Head out to rejoin Mulray and Emma as they met with Martin Sallow's sister.

But there was something intensely thrilling about the idea that the sophisticated, beautiful thirty-something was about to be ravaged right under his nose. Waiting there for her date to finish, he had caught the sense that this situation really might not ever happen to him again, that merely for the sake of experiencing this, he ought to let it play out.

It was difficult to entirely understand why it made him so hard, why it made his heart pound like never before—why his nervous jealousy

seemed to be merging into his arousal to enhance the excitement, turning pain and anger into raw powerful lust.

This had to have been exactly what Julian had felt when he'd set up his wife on her dates.

Jonah breathed deeply, tried almost to meditate. Slowing down his pounding heart, experiencing the bewildering mix of emotions that coursed through them, attempting to ride them and manage them without being overwhelmed.

She was cheating on him. On her husband.

It wasn't a large house, and the television was not up loud—he could hear the quiet, muffled moans and giggles that suggested the early stages of lovers entangling.

He stood up, pushed the door quietly open and walked to the bottom of the stairs, felt himself trembling as curiosity drove his foot onto the first step. Was he insane? Was he turning into some kind of masochist?

But hadn't he been curious about this in the first place, when he was up there with Lily himself?

He proceeded silently, listening to the sounds of heavy breathing, of clothing rustling, of quiet sighs and amused flirtation. The scent of Lily's perfume hung

subtly in the air along with a slight hint of cologne. He lifted his other foot up to the next step. He couldn't do it—couldn't even poke his head up enough to peer through the banister into Lily's bedroom. He was just a big coward.

A step creaked under his foot, freezing him where he stood as a sharp dagger of fear pierced his heart. God. Look at him. Pathetic.

Afraid, jealous, but brutally aroused, Jonah stepped back downstairs, closed the door to the living room, and turned up the volume on the television again. Some guy in a beard was talking, Jonah had no idea who he was.

“...I think it’s clear that the last three deaths have been linked, yes, and that we do have a serial killer here. But whether she has three, four or five bodies to her name so far is not entirely clear. The police are beginning to accept that the worst might be true, however...”

Jonah jumped when the door to the hallway opened silently. He hadn’t noticed that the sounds from upstairs appeared to have stopped.

It was too soon for anything important to have happened yet, wasn’t it?

Lily slipped into the room. She was still wearing her little black dress, in fact her whole outfit appeared to be in place, other than her shoes.

“I thought I’d check on how you’re doing,” she said, her voice low, presumably so there was no chance that her date upstairs could hear. Jonah shivered—there was something irresistibly seductive about her voice—about her whole sexual-extrovert attitude. And he thought that he wasn’t merely imagining a certain glint in her eye, as though she also had other reasons for ducking out of her date to drop in on him.

“Did you really tell him I’m your husband?”

Jonah didn’t know what to do, didn’t know what to say. He sat there, not wanting to give her clear signals as to how he was feeling—because he wasn’t sure how he was feeling himself.

“He’s kind of into exploring that whole thing—just like you,” she said. “Thought I might see if you wanted to find out firsthand what I used to do with Julian.”

“Firsthand?”

He couldn’t help but suck in his breath at that suggestion.

She looked him in the eye. “I’ll stop if you want me to—get rid of him,” she said earnestly. “But all those questions you were asking before—you are curious, aren’t you?”

He stared at her, his stomach seeming to slump into his shoes.

He swallowed, then gave a very slight nod.



Lily cocked her head to urge him up from the sofa to follow her. Jonah took a deep breath, and then he was up, behind her, feeling a little giddy as she led him out into the hallway.

“I told him I’d get us some drinks,” she said, leading him along the corridor toward the kitchen, rather than up the stairs as Jonah expected.

“What’s he like?” Jonah asked, worried he’d be the kind of guy to whom he’d take an immediate dislike.

She shrugged. “He’s got a big prick, isn’t that the important thing?”

Jonah found himself feeling a little intimidated, but as they reached the kitchen doorway, Lily nudged him and giggled.

“Don’t worry—I’m not saying yours is small,” she said. “Far from it—you’re certainly nicely bigger than average. Only this guy—well, you can tell that he’s particularly gifted.”

“And that’s a good thing?” he asked her, trying not to sound insecure. “That’s what you go for when you date men other than your husband?”

She smiled, now reaching up to open a cupboard over the kitchen counter, to retrieve three wine glasses.

“I can tell you’re new at this,” she said. “I’m not sure how it is with other couples like us, but Julian always wanted the guys joining us to be quite physical, quite athletic.”

Jonah took the glasses from her to free her up to track down the wine from the cupboard under the sink, of all places. “He didn’t feel threatened by guys like that?”

“The important thing is that it’s different,” she said. “Oh it’s not just size that matters—it’s how he uses it. But when I was playing with Julian, the main thing was that it was different from what I was used to.”

“I suppose there wouldn’t be any point cheating with your husband’s identical

twin,” Jonah offered a hypothetical.

“No,” she said, opening a drawer to look for a bottle opener. “Julian always said it was his gift to me—strange cock. Enormous cock. He wanted to give me experiences I wouldn’t have with him. I guess that was part of the turn-on for him.”

Jonah’s expression must have made his conflicted feelings appear obvious, for Lily grinned and stroked his cheek. “You have to remember that you’re not married to me, so you feel all kinds of insecurity that you wouldn’t feel if you were like Julian was.”

“I suppose so...”

“It’s rather sweet,” she said. “Jonah, we can stop all this. If you’d rather take things more slowly.”

He shook his head. “I’m not ready for a proper relationship,” he insisted. “I’m seeing... someone else.”

She smiled, “Your investigation.”

He nodded. He wasn’t going to start talking to her about Emma. “I guess I’m pretty messed up.”

“Not at all—you’re still grieving. I am too—I don’t think it would make sense for me to get into something heavy so soon after what happened to Julian—even though I’m fairly sure he’d have been happy for me.”

He nodded, and felt surprised at how disappointed he was that Lily had said what she had.

“That doesn’t mean I don’t want to keep seeing you,” she grinned and stroked his cheek again. “Come on—don’t you want to see how weird this is?”

Weird. Strange how she embraced that—plenty of people engaged in unconventional lifestyles would militarily insist that there was nothing ‘weird’

about them. But then wasn't that what all this was about for Lily? Shaking up her cosy middle-class lifestyle. Adding a bit of 'strange cock' to her routine to give her a thrill now and again.

Why wouldn't a husband want his wife to have a genuine thrill every now and then, even if it wasn't at his own hands?

If you thought about this in a certain way, it almost seemed like the most natural thing in the world to want to share your wife.

"So... what do I do?" he asked her as they edged toward the hallway again.

"What do you want to do?"

"I'm not sure. I mean, I want to watch, but..."

She nodded, and Jonah got the sense that it must have been like this for Julian the first time. Unsure exactly what the procedure was.

"Why don't you just take a seat when we get up there, see how you feel?" she suggested. "If anything at all starts to make you feel uncomfortable, we can stop."

He took another deep breath and nodded his understanding.

"If you feel like joining in—well, you do what you want to," she grinned, wiggled her butt provocatively, and then headed for the stairs.



Lily seemed confident, bright and buzzing with energy as they headed up to the bedroom. She looked incredible in that little dress—was it his imagination, or had she hiked it up? He could see the tops of her stockings—not pantyhose, then

—on her shapely thighs. She was oozing sex.

It made him feel certain that although Julian may have started them out on the journey towards consensual infidelity, Lily must have gotten into

the driver's seat after a while.

Jonah felt his stomach tying itself up into knots as they climbed up to the first floor, rounded the corner, and walked calmly to the bedroom.

The jealousy burned like acid—and it wasn't as though he was really married to Lily. How could married guys like Julian cope with this? Of course, he couldn't really know—Jonah didn't have any experience of being married. He'd had relationships in the past where the sex fizzled after a few months.

Would he have been willing to try this kind of thing to save those relationships?

He tried to push the feelings down. Recalled that he himself was sleeping around, and even had what some might term a relationship with Emma. How could he possibly feel that he should have exclusive rights to Lily?

Turning in to the bedroom, Jonah received a jolt to the heart as he first laid eyes on the other man.

So, it was real then. He was surprised to find just how young the guy was—he seemed to be straight out of university, maybe 22 or 23. Lily certainly had more than 10 or even 15 years on him. He could see why she'd picked him out from the website—she could have typed “tall, dark and handsome” into the search box, and he'd no doubt have come up.

“Hi,” she smiled broadly as they entered, and Jonah felt a touch of jealousy flicker inside him. “This is my husband. Robert, this is Jason.”

“Hi,” Jonah leaned in to shake the guy's hand—and then give him a wine glass.

As Lily had suggested, beneath a thin white shirt, Jason did appear to be quite athletic.

“Hey, nice to meet you,” he said. He had a slightly cocky grin, but Jonah suspected it was more about his own nerves from meeting—and getting physical

—with new people than from being arrogant. “You have a beautiful wife.”

“Thanks,” Jonah said, feeling a touch better as he saw that Jason’s eyes did not match the smile for arrogance.

“There, friends already,” Lily said, pulling the cork out of the Beaujolais before pouring out for the two men, and finally herself.

They clinked glasses, and both Jonah and Lily drained theirs, though Jason merely took a sip. “You want me at my best, right?” he smiled at Lily’s raised eyebrows.

“Of course,” she said. “But you can have a glass?”

He shrugged, and handed the glass to Jonah. “I’d rather have a taste of you,” he said, and surprised both Lily and Jonah by grabbing hold of her arm and pulling her over to him, away from what he saw as her husband.

Lily let out a startled yelp, and Jonah found himself instinctively diving for the glass and bottle of wine she carried—impressing himself at managing to save the carpet a few nasty red splotches.

Hands full of wine in various receptacles, Jonah was a little startled himself to straighten up again and find Lily now kissing her date on the lips right in front of him. The wet sounds of the two sucking on each others’ lips was somehow shocking to Jonah—he’d never seen other people actually having sex before. Not in real life, anyway.

Lily moaned as Jason ran his hands up her butt and round her waist before sliding up and over her breasts, squeezing her, checking out the shape of her cleavage in a way that made Jonah not only jealous—but envious, too.

“We haven’t really done this much before,” Lily said as Jason’s head dipped down to kiss her along her plunging neckline. “Not together, anyway.”

She glanced at Jonah, silently checking he was still okay with this, while raising her eyebrows at Jason’s hastiness.

“Mmm... newbies, huh?” Jason chuckled. “I like newbies. So fresh and...

nervous. Sweet.”

He slipped the straps of Lily's dress off her shoulders, and the garment slipped down to her waist to reveal that the purple and black lace covering her breasts was in fact part of a bodysuit or teddy, not a bra.

Jonah again found himself a little taken aback at the guy's boldness and pace.

"So you've done this a few times, Jason?" he asked.

"Hmm, yes," he said, squeezing and kissing Lily's breasts through her underwear, as she looked over at Jonah with mock-shock in her eyes. "Not always in front of hubby, but sometimes."

"I thought I'd pick someone with a little experience, honey," Lily said, signaling with her eyes for Jonah to take a seat. "You know—show us the ropes."

"Oh, we can use ropes, sure," Jason said, and Jonah wasn't sure whether he was actually making a joke, or hadn't quite understood Lily's reference.

He moved over to Julian's chair in the corner, and Lily said: "Why don't you take your things off, honey? I like to see how you're responding to this."

Jonah felt sudden terror, but standing in front of the chair, he unbuttoned his shirt, and then started unfastening his belt, feeling the pressure of expectation on him to do so. He could hardly refuse—he'd look a fool, and their pretending to be a married couple for Jason would unravel.

It was such a strange experience—and yet when you got down to it, it was just a few people taking off their clothes and fooling around. Society had put such a huge emphasis on sex being between one woman and one man, and made it clear that everything else was abnormal, that going against the grain like this seemed insane.

Yet although his chest was on fire from the strange jealousy he felt, as he finally hauled down his pants and his boxers, Jonah revealed that he was fully hard—

this was an unbelievable thrill.

Lily sat on the edge of the bed, Jason stepping up between her legs, and Jonah

was shocked at what she was clearly about to do—this all seemed so sudden.

Though when he thought about it, they had spent a while at dinner together.

“So you enjoy being with couples, Jason?” he asked the guy now, wondering if he could hear the nervous tremor in his voice, wondering if the guy thought he was being pathetic, popping questions in an attempt to slow what was going on with his ‘wife’.

“Nothing like it,” Jason said, unfastening his fly buttons as Lily fumbled with his belt. “It’s all about the sex—I can leave the relationship stuff to the husband.”

Lily pulled his pants down, revealing a pair of crimson silk boxer shorts that had Lothario written all over them. Jonah caught his breath, and sitting there in the corner, forced himself to remain still, not react to the clamor in his head urging him to intervene.

“It’s not just the sex,” Jason went on. “I like helping people—helping couples spice things up again.”

“And that’s what most of them are doing?”

“Sure—they get bored of marriage after a while, maybe start fantasizing a little, role-playing. Then you know, a lot of married guys find themselves wondering what it would be like watching their wives have sex with someone else.”

“I bet,” Jonah said, trying to put himself firmly in the role in which he was playing.

Lily looked over, giving him a smile that said she was pleased he was giving this a try, and amused he was using it as a chance to find out more about this lifestyle to inform his own investigations.

Then her hands were all over Jason, exploring the shape and size of his manhood through the thin silk boxers, her mouth opening wide in mock-

surprise.

“Mmm... very nice,” she purred, looking over to Jonah again to check on his response. Suitably reassured he wasn’t about to get up and walk out in disgust, she leaned forward and started using her face to explore the shape of Jason’s hardness, her lips finding the tip through the thin material, making him utter a deep groan as she found it.

“You know, there’s nothing like being with a beautiful woman when she’s promised to someone else,” Jason said, running his fingers over Lily’s hair, encouraging her.

“You like it when the husband’s watching?” Jonah asked.

Lily slipped her new lover’s boxer shorts down, and Jonah felt himself gasp in unison with her as she revealed Jason’s impressive cock. It was perhaps only semi-hard, and already somewhat took the breath away. Jonah saw Lily’s eyes light up, which caused a dull throb of hurt inside his chest—and yet somehow also excited him.

“Mmmm... God, you’re so big,” she sighed, beaming broadly as she just looked at it a moment or two, casting another look of surprise Jonah’s way as her hands encircled the massive organ.

It was so downright weird to see that thing in her hands. Another man’s cock.

“Used to freak out when a couple wanted the guy to be there as well,” Jason said, obviously taking pleasure in Lily’s response to his size. “But once I got over it—you know, stopped thinking the husband wants to get into the gay stuff

—once I figured that’s not the way it is with these guys... well, I think it’s better this way.”

“Better?”

Lily kissed the tip of Jason’s cock, sending a jolt of shock and excitement through Jonah’s heart.

“Different kind of energy when the husband’s watching,” he explained. “Wife wants to show off, and she’s not so guilty, ‘cause she can see her

man's really into this.”

Then she was closing her lips around him and pushing forward, her mouth stretching to accommodate him as she took him inside her, moaning as she did so, as if it was some wonderfully sweet dessert she was sampling.

With Jason breathing hard as she moved on him, she used both hands as well as her mouth to coax the beast, periodically breaking off to trail her tongue up along his length, or around his tip.

Jonah found his jealousy simmering down—still there, though now overwhelmed by the arousal as he watched Lily for a while, servicing the huge cock with her pretty face.

Yet Jason seemed to enjoy telling Jonah how much she liked his cock, how good it felt that she was sucking him.

“Look at her—she loves my dick,” he said, taunting Jonah. “She can’t get enough.”

Lily kept glancing at him, her eyes attempting to apologize for her new lover’s teasing, though most of the time her mouth couldn’t let go of his manhood.

When she looked over at him, Jason’s cock still filling her mouth, there seemed a strange intimacy between them that took Jonah a little by surprise—this was their moment, even though there was another man with his cock in her mouth.

Her eyes suggested to Jonah that this tall, dark stranger with his washboard stomach was merely a toy for them to play with.

“It’s so wonderful,” she said, her tone one of wonderment and gratitude for the gift her ‘husband’ had given her, rather than the taunting of Jason. “The way it makes me feel... just to touch it... to put it in my mouth...”

He wondered if Lily was taking this approach because of how he was reacting to Jason’s teasing. Because she was experienced in this kind of thing. If she was, then she was correctly interpreting his preference for her warm affection than the possibility of humiliation.

Jason gave another deep groan, and after a long while, leaned down, encouraging Lily to break off from his hardness to kiss his mouth.

In watching them, in imagining he was a husband and not a single guy who had only really been on one date with this woman, Jonah found that when his rival kissed Lily, it was as shocking, if not more so, than when she actually had her lips around his cock. It just seemed so much more personal—kissing like that was more affectionate, loving.

The affection made him feel much more jealous than the sex.

As they kissed, Jonah was surprised yet again, this time to see Jason's hand

between Lily's thighs, his fingers already inside her.—how had he missed when that had started?

Lily pushed back a little on the bed, and Jason pulled off the rest of his clothes before joining her on the mattress.

They were kissing, and then kneeling up while she remained seated, he pressed his enormous erection between her breasts, crushing them around his hard flesh, taking pleasure in the texture of the lace on his sensitive shaft.

Lily was finding it hard to resist sucking on him, and in between another few glances to see how Jonah was doing, she pulled him back into her mouth.

Jonah felt a sensation of panic gripping him, his mind whirring in a desperate search for more questions to ask Jason, to slow this couple down even though the clock said it was already half an hour after they'd started. Where was the time going? This was all happening so quickly.

But he couldn't come up with anything, had to just sit there and watch Jason manhandling Lily. His clear physical strength and well-defined muscles made it seem easy to simply pull her this way and that, to remove her dress completely and leave her in only her sexy high-cut purple lace teddy. She ended up with her rear pointed skywards as she lay on her front over his lap. Jonah watched him slip aside the purple lace covering her pussy to reveal her pink slit.

He slapped her on the behind—a sharp little crack that drew a huge sigh from Lily, and then a giggle.

“Oh yeah,” she moaned, and he spanked her again, stooping to kiss her cheek as he massaged her flesh, teasing open her pussy lips, giving Jonah a real show.

A few more strikes, and Lily’s rear had a pleasing pink glow, and then she let out a deep cry as his fingers penetrated her again.

God, he was inside her.

Lily looked over to him, and in amongst all her heavy breathing, her sighing, her stirring moans, she offered him a loving smile, her eyes dropping to his lap as he quietly massaged his own hardness in response to the extraordinary display.

Another few spanks of Lily’s behind, and Jason chuckled, “You like that,” he said. “Your husband ever spank you?”

“Oh no,” Lily groaned. “He never spanks me.”

Jonah smiled, enjoying Lily’s performance. He’d never really thought of sex being a performance before this whole thing, before he’d attempted to become

‘Robert’ and be something he wasn’t. But sex could be a real performance—and you could play any role you liked. Lily was an impressive performer—in this character of an insatiable wife, she was incredibly sexy.

Lily was kissing Jason again, leaning up, pushing him back on the bed, gripping his cock again before giving in to her temptation to slip it back into her mouth.

“Mmm... suck it...” Jason groaned, but Lily was looking at Jonah as she did suck on the huge thing, and as he coaxed his own cock in time with her motion, made it seem almost as though she was going down on him.

Then, from somewhere, she pulled out a condom, tearing open the packet as she had his cock still in her mouth. Jonah was a touch surprised—the

requirement of the website for full and regular health checks meant they shouldn't need protection. It was much safer this way, though.

She retrieved the little latex sheath from its foil covering, and was now rolling it down Jason's hardness—and simply the act of preparing it for sex caused an unbelievable pressure to build up within Jonah again—they were going to do it, have full sex right in front of him.

God, the strength of the emotions washing through him—and he wasn't even married to Lily!

She moved forward, kissed him again on the mouth as if to make things even worse for Jonah. And then she lifted one knee, then the other, very slowly over his thighs, his hand reaching under to cup her sex as she moved, before she dropped down to straddle his lap.

For a moment, Jonah wondered if her new lover was inside her already. But then they shifted position a little, specifically to give him a better view, and he saw the younger man's hardness pressing up against the lace covering her body, not inside her.

One last time, Jonah locked eyes with Lily, one of her eyebrows raised in a silent little question. He took a deep breath—in and out—and then gave her a little nod.

For some reason, Jonah felt so very powerful at that moment, granting consent for her to do this. It was probably some form of defense mechanism to help him cope with the huge pressure of another man taking his woman like this.

He was giving her this experience, he was allowing her to take this unusually large cock inside her. He could stop it at any moment—but he had chosen for it to go ahead.

Then Lily lifted slightly, and Jason lined himself up for her, before she tugged aside the narrow band of lace between her legs, and sank on his shaft. And in their role play at least, another man was now fucking Jonah's wife.



He watched her in quiet awe.

Seeing her penetrated, actually watching his huge cock sliding in and out of her

—it was somehow more thrilling than he even suspected it would be.

Particularly when he imagined she was really his wife—or when the face of Emma popped into his head.

Another man's cock inside her, inside his woman.

And the way she looked, open-mouth shock at being so stretched by him, at the way he made her feel as he thrust inside her.

“He's so big, honey,” Lily said, “he's almost all the way inside me... I've never felt so full...”

He held her waist as she began riding him, bouncing on him, her whole body shaking as she slammed down on his piston, her pussy so wet around him.

“You like watching your wife riding strange cock, honey?”

The way she looked at him, really appreciating him for letting her fuck other men, made him feel so alive, and strangely included in all this. It was his gift to her, after all, so went the role-play.

She varied her pace, at times riding him furiously, at others slow and sedate, enjoying the feeling of new cock inside her.

When she dismounted, and crawled on all fours beside Jason, ready for him to take control, her pussy was rosy red and soaking. The other man rose from the bed, ducked briefly to appreciate the beauty of her up-tilted behind, and even taste her wet pussy briefly, before kneeling behind her, that huge prick resting between her cheeks, gently sliding up and down for a few moments.

When he entered her again, she closed her eyes and howled.

“He's going to come inside me, honey. I can feel him, he's so close...”

Watching that thing sinking into her felt so wrong, and yet Jonah felt so pumped,

his body injecting testosterone into his system, making him feel suddenly powerful, his cock harder than ever.

“He’s so swollen... I can feel him throbbing... he’s just going to explode...”

He felt a biological response to the thought of this other man pumping his own potent seed into his wife, jet after jet of thick white come that would threaten the foundations of their relationship.

He wanted to shove the guy out the way and take her himself. But Jonah resisted the temptation, his head leading his actions, his head fixed firmly on the memory of Emma’s disapproval for his seeing Lily again.

Her orgasm was so intense, it seemed almost as though Jonah felt it, too.



Afterward, Lily showed Jason to the front door, covering herself in a thin pink satin bathrobe over her purple lace teddy.

Her new lover hadn’t been in a particular rush to get away after the end of it—

even making the offer of staying for more fun. But Lily had suggested perhaps they call it a night—that she and her ‘husband’ had a lot to talk about.

Jonah remained fairly quiet, feeling a little dazed, particularly after the sight of this other man coming powerfully inside Lily, right in front of him. Even with the knowledge that his rival was using a condom, it was a troubling sight, and despite the dark thrill that Jonah had to admit it had all been.

“I don’t think it works quite in the same way if you’re not actually married,” she said softly, once the front door had clicked shut to confirm their privacy once more as a couple.

He nodded, trying to hide his trembling. “It’s funny— I know we’re not husband and wife, I know nothing between us is serious... and yet I still had this insane jealousy that you were with that guy.”

“The head and the heart aren’t always on the same page.”

“No. Not even in the same book, a lot of the time,” Jonah said. “I think while the head is locked on non-fiction, the heart has its nose buried in a novel.”

Lily’s hand found his semi-hard cock under his boxer shorts, and as her fingers curled around it, it hardened quite suddenly.

“You didn’t come,” she said. “But did you enjoy it?”

He thought for a moment before he said: “Yes. It was the weirdest experience I’ve ever had, but I think on balance, I enjoyed it. I think I understand a little more.”

“That’s the important thing, isn’t it?” Lily chuckled. “You can pick up more ideas for your investigation.”

“Don’t knock firsthand evidence,” Jonah insisted.

“So you want me to help you out with this?” she said, pulling his boxers down just enough to reveal his erection.

He stopped her. “I’m sorry,” he said. “Really I am. I can’t stay tonight.”

She nodded. Disappointed, but looking as though she figured all this had been a little too much for him to cope with. That he might need time to think. She wasn’t entirely wrong if she thought that.

Jonah decided to slip into that character, the man who needed time to think. It was simpler that way, and Lily seemed to have accepted it already. He didn’t want to have to explain Emma to her.

“I’m glad I did it,” he was saying as she showed him to the door once he’d pulled on his clothes again. “It’s like going on the highest roller coaster. I felt so frightened, so sick to my stomach—but I wanted to see what it would be like, wanted to see if I could really cope.”

“And you did cope.”

He smiled. “I surprised myself. You know, I thought I’d feel real anger. I’d be angry at Jason, I’d hate him.”

“But you didn’t.”

He shook his head. “I was so passive, so completely non-aggressive. I wasn’t expecting that at all.”

“You’d accepted this was just a little fun.”

“Maybe. It was exciting watching him with you. Watching him give you pleasure. Feeling I had allowed it to happen. But I had this strong sense that it was just physical—that you like being with me, that you like spending time with me, but with him this was just sex.”

“That’s just how it was.”

“I could imagine myself married to you, and it actually made me feel more secure.”

She smiled, and there was a great sadness in her eyes. Jonah felt a twinge of anguish that he’d reminded her of her huge loss. Stupid.

The night air was so cool it brought goosebumps to his skin. Not very inviting.

The temptation to stay in the warm with Lily was almost overpowering. Well, Emma was expecting him to stay overnight, wasn’t she? She’d objected to it, but then by the end of their last conversation, she’d been fairly resigned to it, hadn’t she?

But that was why he wanted to surprise her. To show up when she wasn’t expecting it, to show her he wanted her more than anyone else, and that if she had reservations about him seeing someone in particular, namely Lily Foster, he just plain wouldn’t.

“Were you disappointed?” he asked her, shivering a little and wishing he’d brought a thicker jacket.

“Disappointed?”

“That I didn’t join in... with Jason.”

“Oh no,” she said. “That was usually the way with Julian. Far more interested in watching. And you’re a beginner.”

“Such a beginner,” Jonah chuckled. “When I left Oxford—I think I was almost a virgin.”

“You’re sewing your oats—doesn’t matter that it’s 10 years after most guys sew theirs.”

God, she looked so beautiful, seemed so very sensual and sexy, this insatiable wife, this promiscuous woman.

He leaned in to kiss her cheek, a simple peck goodbye, but it turned into a long, tender kiss of the mouth. Tasting the sharp wine in her mouth, sucking on lips that had been stretched around another man’s shaft earlier, slipping his tongue in the mouth that had sampled another man’s emissions that night.

“I was supposed to ask you about the book,” he said.

“The book?”

“Julian’s book. I found a copy in Nate’s belongings.”

“Oh, you did?”

“Are you sure you guys never met him, my brother?”

“No,” she said, her voice confident. “At least, I didn’t. It could be that he met your brother... while he was out with other people, when I wasn’t with him.

That was rare but it did happen. And recently... well, you said he wasn’t actually dating anyone, right? Women or couples.”

“But he was interviewing them,” Jonah said. “About the whole dating thing, probably, the whole wife-sharing thing. So it’s possible he interviewed my brother.”

“And that would be too much of a coincidence, since they both ended up dead in hotel rooms?”

Jonah sighed. A coincidence, just like the coincidence he’d uncovered suggesting that Julian had written the obituary for Lord Moss. An obituary that was actually used some months after Julian himself had died.

“I think coincidences can happen,” he said. “But I’m skeptical.”

Lily nodded, pulled her robe together more tightly, to keep out the chill breeze.

“Well,” she said. “I hope we can continue what we started some time.”

“That would be nice,” he said, thinking it was likely a white lie considering how Emma felt about her.

Well, at least he’d done what he’d set out to do this evening—and come away with a couple of interesting little factoids he might not have otherwise come up with. And could it possibly be mere coincidence that Julian Foster could have interviewed both Douglas Moss and Nate Fielding for his book, and now all three of them were dead?

Three

It was still summer, but he felt so very cold walking down the steps from Lily’s front door to the street. He couldn’t help feeling he’d rejected her bed, and now he’d go out in the hope of finding Emma, and quite possibly miss her.

He’d end up returning to the apartment in West India Quay alone, and Emma would assume he’d stayed the night with Lily—and perhaps be angered by that.

The weather had changed quite distinctly while he’d been inside with Lily. It was so much colder now than he remembered while going in. Colder than it had been all summer. That was London for you.

The street was silent, still. There was the standard quiet hum of traffic that you always got in London, but it seemed far off. Nevertheless, Jonah felt a touch exposed away from the safety of a busy street. There was

something menacing about the cars parked along either side of the street: anybody could be hiding in one of them, watching him. Ready to attack.

The houses here all had front gardens, or steps down to basement apartments, and with bushes here and there, there seemed an awful lot of places for bad people to hide.

He was telling himself he was being paranoid, but then fifty yards down the road, he froze as he heard a voice.

“Jonah? Jonah Fielding?”

He turned to find a pale-faced man, with freckles and, though the light of the street lamps altered everything, what looked like red hair.

Jonah tensed, waiting for the man to produce a knife or a gun or something, waiting for the danger.

Then he recognized the man.

“Harold Keeley. We met briefly in the Hilton.”

Jonah let out a deep breath saturated with relief, his whole body relaxing. He hardly wanted to deal with the press at this time, but a journalist wasn't the menacing threat he feared just now.

“What are you doing here?”

He glanced this way and that, as though worried he might be overlooked, followed, whatever. The paranoia was catching, it seemed.

“I was following up a lead,” he said. “Needed to talk to Lily Foster.”

Jonah chuckled, “Good luck, Mr Keeley. I'm not sure she's going to be big on the idea of talking to the press.”

He had Mulray's warning in the back of his mind: don't, whatever you do, talk to the press. He gave Keeley a decidedly cold shoulder and continued on his way toward Uxbridge Road and the Shepherd's Bush Tube Station, walking as quickly as he could without running, to make it difficult for the reporter to keep up.

“Maybe you could help a guy out,” Keeley said, managing to walk with him, behind him.

“I’m not supposed to talk to the press, Mr Keeley,” he said.

“Did I write what you said to me before?”

That was a definite ‘no’. Jonah hadn’t seen anything in the press about the killer meeting her victims through an online adult matchmaking service like No Strings. His little tip to Keeley as he came out of the Hilton that day, the day after Martin Sallow had been killed, had gone nowhere.

“I’m in it for the long game,” the reporter said. “I’m not doing daily write-ups on nonsense theories. I want the killer, nothing less.”

“What, to interview her?”

“Perhaps. To unmask her, certainly. To make sure she faces justice.”

Jonah sighed, and continued walking. Keeley continued to hound his heels.

“Julian Foster was a regular visitor at Lord Moss’s home in Chiswick, did you know that?” he said.

Jonah’s ears did prick up at that. But he didn’t want to get lulled into giving in to this journalist based on information that wasn’t really worth anything.

“He was an obituary writer,” Jonah said. “He was interviewing the guy as part of the obituary his newspaper was putting together. They do that apparently—write obituaries before someone actually dies.”

Keeley said: “He was going round there way more than just for an interview. Or if he was, it was more than any single obituary could hold. Biography, maybe.”

“Who did you get this from?”

“A neighbor.”

“Trustworthy?”

“Absolutely.”

“Julian Foster was writing a book, but I don’t think it was a biography of Lord Moss.”

“Really? Lily Foster told you? What did she tell you?”

Jonah felt his head reeling a little. He wanted to trust this guy, wanted to grill him to find out exactly what he knew—since he hadn’t written an article about all this yet, so far as Jonah knew. But the guy was a journalist—you couldn’t trust journalists, could you? And Mulray had warned him not to talk to the press...

“Look,” Keeley pushed forward so he was walking beside Jonah, forcing Jonah to make room for him on the sidewalk. “D’you want a lift somewhere? We could talk. Off the record. I’d never print a word of what you told me, I swear. Nothing you weren’t happy with, at any rate.”

Jonah let out a frustrated breath, “What are you trying to get at here, Mr Keeley?”

You’re saying there was a link between Lord Moss and Julian Foster...”

“Pretty big coincidence, them being so chummy.”

“So what, Julian Foster was killed because of what he found out about Lord Moss? You’re saying there was a motive? What about the other Hotel Killings?”

Keeley said, “I don’t know yet. It’s early days. I want to know why the details surrounding Lord Moss’s death are being kept so secret—and yet Julian Foster is right out there. They’re linked. And the police are saying Foster’s one of the Black Widow’s now.”

Jonah paused, slowing his pace. “Julian Foster wrote another book, limited distribution. Only people he’d met had a copy. And my brother had a copy.”

Keeley said: “They are connected. I think they’re more than just random victims of a psychopath.”

Jonah tapped his foot on the pavement, frustrated. What the reporter was saying was music to his ears, of course—that Nate hadn’t just been randomly slain, that there was a reason for it, that there was some wider causation for it all. But he knew the pain inside him made it all too tempting to pick up any fanciful conspiracy theory that played to his need for a bigger meaning in it all.

Was Keeley really onto something, or was he just a conspiracy theorist looking for sensationalist headlines?

“You want a lift somewhere?” the reporter said now. “I parked just round the corner. We could talk. Just talk. Off the record. Swap notes.”

“Swap notes?” Jonah stepped up his pace, indicating his doubt in Keeley’s position.

“You’re looking into it all, aren’t you?” he said. His nostrils flared a little, irritating, except that somehow it denoted real passion in this reporter. “You know there’s rumors flying around Fleet Street that you started seeing Lily Foster? Sleeping with her. Consoling each other and all that stuff. But you’re investigating, aren’t you?”

“I can’t talk to the press.”

“You’ve been avoiding their phone calls. But they’ll start staking out your house soon, Jonah. The interest in all this Black Widow stuff is exploding.”

“Is that some kind of a threat?” Jonah said, anger lacing his voice.

“Not at all. I just think we can help. Two heads better than one, and all that.

Better access, more ears to the ground, you know?”

Jonah sighed. The offer of a lift was tempting, too. He wasn’t imagining the first few drops of cold rain in the air. The weather was changing, and he really didn’t want to be caught out in a cold rainstorm right now, trying to find out where Emma had gone to.

“You know the big reason the police aren’t linking Lord Moss to the Black Widow?” Keeley said now, as though pitching big suspense

questions to try to tempt Jonah into his car.

“What?”

“They all had sex with the Black Widow before she killed them. It’s why she’s called the Black Widow, huh. But Lord Moss was impotent.”

Jonah stopped on the street. “Impotent?”

“Couldn’t get it up, could he? Couldn’t have slept with any Black Widow.”

Jonah sighed. Now he felt actual raindrops.

“You’re car’s close by?”

“Stone’s throw.”

He hunched his shoulders instinctively to keep the rain from going down his neck. You could hear it falling now, it was heavy enough to make a whispering murmur.

“You can take me to Shoreditch?”

“Course.”



“Tell me something, Mr Keeley. Honestly. Have you been following me?”

“Following you?”

“Or any of your Fleet Street colleagues, as far as you know?”

Keeley had a little red battered Renault parked only yards away around the corner. Jonah was mildly relieved to climb in, he would have been soaked through, even on the relatively short walk to the Tube.

“I don’t know about them. I don’t have time to follow anyone.” Keeley pulled his safety belt down, and the moment it clicked in place, they were pulling out into the road. “I speak to people, see?” he said in his hint of South London. “If they won’t talk to me on the phone, I might go to their house, see if I can’t persuade them. If they won’t, they won’t.”

“I’ve heard that some journalists aren’t so kind.”

He smiled, ran a hand through his overlong red hair to keep the rain from dripping down his face. “There’s some offensive people call themselves journalists,” he said. “You think you’re being followed?”

“I know I am,” Jonah said. “I’ve seen them.”

“Haven’t heard about anyone from my neck of the woods getting that interested in you. Still only whispers about whether you’re commiserating with Mrs Foster, though that might translate to something soon. Not enough on that to provoke any kind of circus, though.”

Keeley turned out onto the Uxbridge Road, a somewhat risky maneuver joining the flow of the traffic, though he didn’t seem to care much for the possibility of nudging into anyone, and from the state of his vehicle, he probably had done so fairly often.

He didn’t care much about the blaring horns throwing anger his way, either. The other cars, though, did move over for him, the state of his car perhaps suggesting to them that if they didn’t, he’d just hit them.

The reporter drove in an odd style, leaning forward over the wheel, hunching his shoulders a little, his gaze intent on the road in front yet virtually ignoring anything around him. He looked impatient to get wherever he was going.

“If you saw them tailing you, might’ve wanted you to know they were,” he said.

“Put you under a bit of pressure.”

“What, to stop trying to find out who killed my brother?”

He shrugged, “Maybe. Or concerned you’ll get into trouble. Police? I can’t see they’d be following you unless they had suspicions about you,

though.”

Even this time of night, the traffic was fairly terrible, particularly going round Shepherd’s Bush Common, and past the entrance to the Westfield Centre. More than a few times, Jonah was sure they were going to hit someone, or be hit themselves. It was mildly terrifying being a passenger in Keeley’s car.

“You said Julian was writing a book, but it probably wasn’t a biography?”

“Uh... yeah,” he said, preferring the man to focus on driving rather than conversation. “I mean, it’s possible he was writing a biography. But we found his account on an online adult dating website, and it looked like he was trying to interview people about their experiences on it.”

Jonah suddenly feared saying too much about Julian Foster’s online adventures, that Lily might not be so thrilled that he was talking to the press about all this.

But she’d told the police about Julian’s use of the No Strings website.

He’d just leave out the parts about Lily using it, or about her role in their wife-sharing days.

“He was writing about people using an online dating website?” Keeley seemed disappointed. “Where’s the interest in that?”

“It’s not so much dating as one night stands,” Jonah said.

“One night stands? It’s a sex encounters website?”

“Something like that. It’s called No Strings.”

Keeley was silent for a long while, and Jonah thought at first he was concentrating on driving as they passed through Kensington. But then he said:

“Moss couldn’t get it up. He wouldn’t be using a sex website to meet women.”

“I guess not. How long has he been impotent, d’you know? Has he always been that way?”

Keeley shook his head, “That I do not know. Only so much I can get from my man in the services.”

The hint of sources in the security services made Jonah think how useful it might be to trust this reporter, to swap notes. It was dangerous, but Keeley might open doors for him, as he wanted Jonah to open doors for him.

“I’ll talk to Lily Foster, see if she’ll speak with you,” he said.

For the first time since they’d climbed in the car, Keeley turned to look at him, his face softening somehow, almost to likability. “That would be fantastic if you could,” he said. “I’m not here to dish the dirt on her husband, you know.”

“No,” Jonah said. “I don’t think you are.”

“So tell me about this website—you know Julian Foster was using it. Was your brother?”

The rest of the way to Shoreditch, Jonah went through what he knew about his brother and almost everything in the case he’d uncovered so far—with one exception. He didn’t talk about Lily Foster and the way her husband had been sharing her with other men. Was it relevant? Probably not.

“So your brother was using it for a few years...” Keeley said as they passed Green Park and Buckingham Palace before a drive along The Mall, heading through some of the more touristy parts of the city.

“I think so. Julian Foster was, certainly.”

“So let’s say a few years back, Lord Moss might’ve been using it, too. Somehow Julian Foster discovered they had that in common. He wasn’t... they weren’t...

gay. I don’t think.”

“I don’t think so.”

“I’ve never heard that about Lord Moss. So probably no chance they met each other through the website...”

Keeley was silent as they passed Trafalgar Square and headed along The Strand.

That intense stare of his, with those pale blue eyes, hid whether he was thinking about the case or the traffic.

Julian Foster wasn't gay—Jonah felt that Lily would have told him something like that if he had been. She had no reason not to trust him with a secret like that, if she trusted him with the secret of their swinging. But what if he'd met Lord Moss while they'd been involved in their wife-sharing exploits?

He felt awkward about talking to Keeley about it. He did feel he was beginning to trust the journalist, strangely, but Lily's secret was for her to give up, not him.

He'd have to talk to her about sharing the details with Keeley.

If he'd met Lord Moss again, to interview him for the obituary article, and he recognized him from some kind of incident sharing Lily Foster, perhaps, then perhaps Julian Foster had decided that Lord Moss offered him some useful experiences for his next book.

They headed up through Holborn and along the Clerkenwell Road to Old Street before heading down Great Eastern Street toward Shoreditch.

"Where d'you need to be?" he asked Jonah.

"Queen of Hoxton."

Keeley nodded, and almost immediately turned off the main road onto a smaller street, now he knew their destination. "Not a bad place."

"Just meeting some friends there."

He nodded again. "The first book Julian Foster wrote—you happen to know what that was about? Lily Foster show you?"

"It was a novel."

"Novel. Okay. So you think the next book was going to be a novel? About characters who use a sex dating website?"

“Perhaps. The first one was about various couples, and they were using a matchmaking website, I think.”

They were driving through a warren of little streets, full of offices and vaguely light commercial looking buildings, and Jonah had to hope Keeley knew where he was going: he was completely baffled as to where they were.

Then they came past a pub on one side of the street, and Jonah thought he vaguely recognized where they were, and then a few moments more and they had arrived, a little place on the corner, painted black, with only a small neon-lit sign above the door to identify it as the Queen of Hoxton.

Nate had taken him here a fair few times during his visits to the capital.

“Okay.” Keeley said, pulling up opposite. “Here we are.”

“Thanks for the lift.” The rain had eased into a thin gloomy drizzle, but even so, Keeley had saved him a lot of bother.

“Talk to Lily Foster, will you?”

“I will.”

“We can help each other, Jonah.”

Jonah nodded, said: “Maybe, maybe.”

Four

There was no sign of either Emma or Mulray in the Queen of Hoxton. He searched on both floors. It wasn't a huge place. He even asked the woman behind the bar, who could barely recall serving anyone fitting their descriptions, let alone having any idea where they might have gone.

The music was a little loud for conducive conversation, perhaps they'd gone somewhere a little quieter to talk with Martin Sallow's sister.

He did check in a few bars and pubs nearby, some of which were just as loud, none of which bore results.

He felt a touch gloomy as he resigned himself to heading home, having missed them. It wasn't even so much that he had missed an opportunity to meet the close relative of another victim, but the fact that Emma would think he was staying the night with Lily Foster, that she might be annoyed at him.

There were no messages on his mobile phone. He sent her a text, saying he'd been looking for her, that he'd left Lily's house and come to find her at the Queen of Hoxton. There was no instant reply, which made him assume she and Mulray were still talking with Martin Sallow's sister somewhere.

In the depressing drizzle, he walked all the way down through the City to the Tower Gateway station. The tall buildings whipped up the wind, flinging the rain at him.

From there, it was a short ride on the Docklands Light Railway home, but it seemed to take forever.

And then back at the apartment, he tapped in the code, opened the front door and all the lights were blazing.

“What the—”

He was baffled for a moment, but then Emma stepped out from the bedroom—

and behind her was none other than Detective Mulray.

“Oh, hey!” Emma said, beaming at him, her cheeks slightly pink either from alcohol or heat. “I was just giving Detective Mulray the grand tour, you don’t mind, do you?”

“Hello again,” said the attractive Detective, looking completely cool as usual in her smart suit, unfazed by Jonah’s surprise at their being here.

Since when had Emma and Mulray been such good buddies? And why did Mulray need a grand tour of an apartment she’d already visited?

“You have fun with Lily?” Emma said, and came over to greet him with a smile and a kiss. Her hair seemed a little mussed up, and it made Jonah wonder how much she’d had to drink that evening. She had the faint taste of sweet liquor on her lips, while her coconut perfume seemed to have a slightly different note to it that cast mystery over her evening without him.

“I guess so,” he said. “What have you guys been up to?”

“We met Martin Sallow’s sister, Carolyn, and a few of his friends,” Emma said, backing away from him, heading for the kitchen.

“Useful?” he asked.

“She’s still quite shell-shocked,” Mulray said, folding her arms in front of her chest, bringing to his attention several undone shirt buttons, the upper reaches of her white lacy bra just visible.

“We couldn’t really ask her too much,” Emma said from the kitchen as she fetched a glass, filled it with water.

“It’s still very early,” Jonah actually felt vaguely relieved, that he hadn’t really missed anything. That it had been too early to grill Martin Sallow’s people.

“Martin Sallow’s friends were a little more forthcoming,” Emma said. “They all used to use our website, by the way. Easy sex, they saw it. Why not?”

Jonah looked at Mulray, a huge told-you-so in his eyes.

She shrugged, said: “I’m going to have to talk to my colleagues again. I guess we have to start pursuing that angle.”

Jonah laughed, but was pleased to have forced the issue.

Emma brought two glasses of water back over, one for herself and one for the Detective. He was a little surprised at the friendly glance between them as she handed the glass to the brunette. These two really were getting on.

“You’re friend Emma has got herself a date,” Mulray said, and gave Jonah the kind of taunting look that said to him: well, you date plenty of other women, why shouldn’t Emma see other men?

“A date?” he looked at Emma.

She blushed, “It’s just for the investigation, right? Clement—he’s Martin Sallow’s best friend. So I can find out more about Martin.”

Jonah felt a trifle breathless. Part of him was horrified at the thought of losing her to someone else, that she would slip away because he could not, yet, promise her exclusivity. But part of him couldn’t help finding the prospect faintly thrilling. Emma acting all sexually voracious, finding excitement in the arms of another man, then coming back to him to tell him about it. So against the rules for how women were seen by society: that they should be chaste and virtuous—

yet that whole breaking of rules thing was so very alluring.

Sure, Emma was free to see other guys. Jonah had never had any intention of getting into a stable relationship, not while the murderer of his brother was still out there. But after his recent experiences with Lily

Foster, and his discovery of their lifestyle, perhaps he'd had his head turned to something new.

He was curious how it would feel to know that his Emma was out there seeing someone else. Would he experience the same strange excitement Julian Foster had felt with his wife?

"Sounds like a good idea," he said, trying to act calm. He looked at Mulray.

"You're trying to get her to be your stooge as well, huh? Charm her way into this guy's bed, so she can get the kind of information you can't?"

Mulray laughed, and he thought she was a little surprised at how blasé Jonah

seemed to be about Emma going to someone else's bed. "It wasn't my idea, can you believe it?"

She looked almost proud of Emma. Certainly appreciative.

Then she said: "I have to be going. You're seeing him Saturday, right?"

"Yes," Emma said, blushing furiously again.

Mulray nodded, "It might be a good idea for us to talk beforehand."

Emma smiled, "To get my questions straight, right?"

"Something like that."



And then it was just them, and Emma launched herself at him.

By the time they reached the bed, the blonde's skirt was gone, leaving her in her pink panties and white t-shirt. Jonah turned to find a hungry expression on her face, though there wasn't time to comment on it before she pushed him sharply back onto the bed. Jonah didn't protest. He

already felt things thickening up down below at the sight of the young blonde in her panties and a t-shirt that showed just a hint of her midriff.

“Did you fuck her?” she said, kneeling down on the bed, reaching down to drag his pants and underwear off his body.

“No,” he said, assuming she meant Lily Foster.

Straddling him, he felt her weight bear down on him, her body so warm against his, particularly the part gently pressing down on his hardness, her hips beginning to gyrate to demonstrate her need.

“You know, I wouldn’t have minded.” Her tone suggested she’d had some kind of change of heart about Lily Foster. It made Jonah suspect that Mulray had spoken to her, either pressing the case that it was useful for Jonah to see Lily, or reassuring her that Lily was no threat to what she had going with Jonah.

“I didn’t need to,” he said. “You were right about that.”

Jonah pulled her to him, his hand slipping through her silky hair to hold her head as she kissed his mouth. Such a sweet one, whenever he was with her, he wondered how he’d been so fortunate as to secure so much attention from such a pretty young woman.

“So what happened?” she asked him, her voice breathy as she continued to grind her pussy against his shaft, only the thin pink cotton of her panties keeping them apart.

Jonah pushed her hair out of her face again, and ducked to kiss her neck. “She had a date with someone else, actually.”

“Someone else? So you didn’t get to talk to her about the book?”

“Oh, I did. And I saw her with her date.”

“She invited you in, while she was seeing some other guy?”

“Told him I was her husband, that I liked to watch her cheating.”

She gasped, with a good splash of melodrama in her bemusement as she now sat up to show him how mock-shocked she was. “You watched her

doing him?”

The way she broke out into a smile just then almost made it seem as though she was relieved, that Lily Foster was confirmed as a serial man-eater, that there was zero percent chance that she would steal Jonah away from her.

“It was quite an experience,” he said. “I wanted to try to understand how Julian might have felt... you know...”

“Sharing his wife?”

Jonah groaned as she rode his shaft, her hips tilting as she rubbed herself against him, teasing him with her availability. Looking up at Emma, he really was in danger of falling for her, he decided. She was so very beautiful, and so much fun. Only, she didn’t seem like the kind of person to go for the whole love thing.

Did she? They’d started dating on a no-commitment website, and had continued to have fun together because it was fun. She’d never said she was looking for anything more—she’d never looked for anything more with a guy before.

At her stage in life, it was all about having fun, that was all.

He even suspected that if he ever did start going head over heels for her, and she realized that, she might decide to end things.

“So what was it like?” she asked him in between sucking on his lips.

For a moment, he had to think, the oh-so-cute blonde draped all over him proving a little too much distraction.

He said, “I was trying to imagine that she was my wife, that I was in love with her. And I guess... it was quite strange.”

“I’ll bet it was.”

“It was pretty hot just to see, you know. Two attractive people having sex. I guess guys like that, whoever they are. But this was watching someone you cared about, someone you wanted to have a good time.”

“Right,” Emma looked at him, fascinated, lifting her head briefly so he could glance down her t-shirt to take in the beautifully rounded breasts nestled inside.

“Because you were imagining being her husband.”

“I wanted her to have an amazing experience... and I wanted to have been the husband who allowed her this amazing experience, who let her have sex with this other man simply because he could.”

Emma slowly pulled herself up so she was sitting astride him again, her hips still gently rocking her pussy against his cock.

“I think that’s really nice,” she said, genuinely awestruck. “You get pleasure in her pleasure. In giving her pleasure through the other man.”

“And watching her with that other guy... it may just be how women are when they have a guy inside them like that... but she became so much more... I don’t know... beautiful.”

“More beautiful?”

“I don’t know. Confident. She took on this extra air of self-confidence, and it was so... sexy. I guess she had an extra man there to make her feel desired, and just knowing that... I guess she just exuded that confidence...”

Jonah drew in his breath with unconcealed awe as the pretty blonde pulled off her t-shirt, to reveal her shapely body and a bright scarlet satin and lace bra doing its best to contain her cleavage.

“I guess that’s how Julian probably thought about it,” she said.

She closed her eyes briefly as the sensations of their friction overcame her a little. Jonah looked down, he could see the head of his cock lodged between her thighs as Emma leaned back, moaning as a dreamy smile spread across her face.

He trailed his hands down from her waist to her thighs, loving the smoothness of her skin.

She said: “You’re really okay about me seeing Clement on Saturday?”

Blushing again. He said: “We never said we were exclusive, did we?”

“No, we didn’t. But we see each other pretty regularly.”

“And you don’t mind the fact that I see other women.”

“No, I don’t. I kinda like it, actually,” she leaned forward to kiss him again, as though trying to prove that she enjoyed his straying ways.

“But you haven’t seen any other guys since we had that first date?”

She shook her head. “I haven’t really needed to. And I wasn’t sure how... you know... how you’d feel about it.”

He kissed her neck, then down her chest, and as he found the warm swell of her breasts, slipping her bra down to reveal her stiff little nipples and take them inside his mouth, he felt her pressing herself down more forcibly on his hard cock.

“Are you planning on sleeping with him?”

He thought back to that first time he met Lily. He hadn’t been planning on sleeping with her. Had Mulray known he would be seduced? Possibly. Was Mulray hoping Emma would be seduced by this guy, Clement? Possibly.

And yet, Jonah didn’t feel entirely horrified at that.

“I don’t know, I guess I think it’ll be like a first date, maybe he’ll think I’m interested, and he’ll open up...”

“You know what happened on our first date.”

“That wasn’t the same. That wasn’t really a date, that was a hook-up.”

“While I was watching Lily...” he said, switching to Emma’s other nipple, “...I thought about how it might feel to know you’re seeing another man.”

He looked up to see her eyes blazing, as though he’d suddenly tapped into one of her all-time-favorite sexual fantasies.

“Really?”

He shrugged, wary about straying anywhere near the “L” word when talking about his feelings for her, this girl who had never gone for stable relationships before.

“I don’t know,” he said, “I was just curious to see how it would feel to be in that situation with someone I really... you know... cared about.”

She beamed at that, and now slowly pulled away from him, edging back between his legs. “You care about me,” she seemed happy enough. Jonah was relieved.

“You want to pretend we’re married, so we can really see what all this wife-swapping is like?”

She giggled, and drew out a moan from him as she trailed her tongue slowly along his full length, from base to tip.

“Wife-sharing,” he said. “Julian’s book is all about wife-sharing, not really swapping. And mainly, that was what he did with Lily.”

“Did she tell you anything more about the book? About why Nate had a copy?”

He shook his head, “She thinks maybe Nate could have met Julian some other time, they didn’t meet him together. I wonder if Julian interviewed Nate for his second book.”

Emma nodded, “We have to look through all his messages, see if Nate’s there in the system.”

“He met Lord Moss, by the way. He wrote the guy’s obituary—I saw his notes.

Interviewed him for it.”

“Interesting.”

Jonah groaned as he felt her slip the tip of his cock inside her hot mouth, her hand gently pumping his shaft as she sucked on his swollen helmet.

He stroked her silky hair out of her face, and did his best to resist the temptation to simply unload in this pretty girl's mouth.

Oh, she was irresistible.

He tried to think about the case as a distraction strategy, a delaying strategy. He did not want to finish now.

"Oh," he said, "Something else I forgot to tell you."

"What?" She broke off briefly from his cock, sliding the engorged tip around her soft cheeks and over her lips, feeling his sensitive flesh against her velvet skin.

Adoring his cock.

"I got a lift over to Shoreditch with a journalist from the Guardian."

"A journalist? But Mulray said..."

"I know, I know. But I think he's okay."

Jonah moaned as she licked his shaft, then sank down on him again, the heat of her mouth enveloping him, threatening to make him erupt.

"He... told me Julian Foster had been seeing Lord Moss at his house... quite a lot..." he said, gazing up at the ceiling as she assaulted his hardness, bobbing her head on his length to the point where he was just barely managing to hold on. "It was too often just to be interviews for the obituary."

At last, he had to stop her. "I'm not going to have anything left," he said.

"We wouldn't want that," she smiled, sitting up to slip off her bra, and then while still holding up her behind, sliding her panties down her thighs.

Then she said: "So was he talking to Lord Moss about all that stuff for his book, too? Lord Moss was into the whole wife-sharing thing?"

Then she was kissing her way up his stomach, a last squeeze of his hardness in her hands before she made her way up his chest, trailing her

velvet breasts all over his rigid, hot shaft. She straddled him, knees planted either side of his waist, although she was a touch too high to take him inside her sex.

She kissed him hungrily, and Jonah found his hands in easy position to sweep up the back of her thighs and find the pleasing roundness of her behind. He could never get enough of Emma's kiss. The way she sucked on his lips, the way she used her tongue to explore his mouth—it seemed so sensual, so dirty, so overtly

sexual.

“Lord Moss was impotent,” Jonah said. “He couldn't get it up.”

“Doesn't mean he couldn't share his wife, though, right?”

Jonah nodded. She had a point. “But he was impotent...”

“Doesn't mean he doesn't get turned on. He just can't get hard enough for penetration. You said you thought it was exciting to experience the giving of Lily to that other man... Maybe Lord Moss felt the same way about sharing his wife.

And because he couldn't penetrate her himself...”

Jonah felt some strange kind of logic clicking into place. If Lord Moss was into this whole thing, that would make some kind of sense. And it would connect up more of the dots in the Hotel Killings that followed.

One of his hands now found itself curling around the blonde's thigh, slipping up to find her pussy so wet already a dribble of her juices had seeped down her leg.

He felt his manhood twitch at the thought of how horny she was, of how she might want to be satisfied.

“The journalist—Harold Keeley, that's his name—I didn't tell him about the wife-sharing part. I told him about Julian's book, but I need to ask Lily before I talk to him about the wife-sharing stuff, I think.”

“Of course you do,” Emma said, and there was none of that reluctance to let him talk to Lily any more. What had Mulray said?

To his surprise, she edged forward, her knees lodging under his armpits momentarily before she lifted one up over his shoulder, then the other, and her glistening sex was now just inches from Jonah's face, all he could see as he looked up, and it was such a turn-on that she wanted him to serve her like this.

"You like it like this, huh, sweetie?" she grinned, looking down on him as she sat back, hands on his chest to support her body.

"Love it," Jonah beamed as her pussy nudged down against his face, her dusting of golden down tickling his nose a little, and every breath he took filled with her coconut-accented spice.

He had the most wonderful view up to her pretty face as she found a comfortable position over him.

"I think I need to be a little more forceful with you, judging by some of your dates recently," she joked, pressing her exquisite womanhood down on his mouth, then closing her eyes while emitting a deep feral moan as he opened his mouth to taste her, his tongue slipping into her sensitive folds to sample her nectar.

"Yes, Ma'am!" Jonah chuckled, but then he was stifled as she leaned forward to take control of the situation, smothering him with her hot, wet pussy, placing one hand on his head to support herself while positioning his mouth perfectly where she wanted it.

She was so wet as he feasted on her, but though he loved her flavor, what made his hands slip down to find his quivering hardness were the noise she made—her little gasps, the whispered curses, the scintillating moans, all underlined by the deepest of breathing as she panted for air.

As he felt her climax coming, however, he dropped his manhood, his hands reaching up to grasp her hips and then her narrow waist, pulling her down on him so she would not fear she was hurting him, so she would lose herself in his hunger, let go of her need.

Then she leaned back, looking down at his face lodged between her thighs, her hand reaching back to seek out his big hard cock as though needing proof of his enjoyment before she could leap off her own cliff.

Proof he gave her, and he saw the brightness flash through her eyes and restart her beaming smile as she felt how much she was turning him on.

And with one hand forward on his head, one hand back on his cock, she rode him like a breathless Lady Godiva, until she was screaming and quivering and coming all over his face, and as he saw her pretty face overcome by the sensations she was feeling, not for the first time he thought he caught sheer surprise in her features, suggesting she was never expecting this particular position to do much for her until she'd tried it.



“I can see why your regular friend Jessica’s always clamoring for more,” Emma said afterwards, as her breathing came under control only to be fired up again as he spooned against her, and now slipped his hardness from behind her into her slippery folds.

“I’m glad you enjoyed it,” he said, filling her, sinking his hardness inside her up to the hilt.

“You think the killer is like that? Taking what she wants, then ending it with a knife?”

“I’m not sure,” he said, letting out a quiet grunt as he thrust into her, her upper leg lifting to offer him easier access, her foot touching down on his thigh. “I think it would take something of a dominant female, don’t you? A submissive woman might kill a man defensively, perhaps, but she wouldn’t go looking for trouble, would she?”

“Some women have rape fantasies, apparently.”

“I suppose so.”

“Maybe this one just takes it a little further—she gets off on killing her attacker.”

“I don’t think Nate would’ve been into rape fantasies,” Jonah said, then as she turned her head, he tasted her mouth, sucking her sweet lips, wondering if she could detect the remnants of her own juices on his skin.

“He was probably into the whole sleeping with married women thing, though, maybe even while their husbands watched, don’t you think?” Emma said, and he saw her hand slip down between her legs, touching her clit while he continued to drill his hardness inside her gloriously hot, wet pussy.

“I’m not sure that means he’d be into the whole rape fantasy thing.”

“But it’s possible. You know there were things about your brother you had no idea about.”

“I suppose so.”

“So we have a woman who either gets off on fucking and killing guys, or a woman with some kind of grudge against married men who commit adultery—

or allow their wives to commit adultery.”

“I feel like we need a chalkboard or something in here,” Jonah said. “This bedroom’s become a crime lab.”

Emma pulled off him, and now twisted and pushed up her butt, presenting it for him clearly to take from behind. He wasn’t going to last much longer, but the sight of her presenting herself like this, almost like some animal now craving a little of his alpha male, he couldn’t resist.

Approaching from behind her, he placed one hand on her lower back, and with the other guided his trembling hardness to the rosy red lips of her soaking pussy.

She let out a deep, guttural groan as he pushed forward, slipping inside her to fill her completely, his large cock seeming to graze against every part of her tender channel. Two hands on her waist, and he powered into her, drawing out those sexy sighs and breathless moans that sparked electricity inside him.

Then she was cursing again, and he’d never heard cursing you might term ‘beautiful’ before—but here it was, coming out of the mouth of a pretty blonde who proved insatiable whenever she was around him.

Her hand reached back to rub her clit as he found himself succumbing to the powerful forces inside him, so that as he felt his end nearing, her own groans and gasps were picking up in tandem.

Then she let go, both hands reaching in front, kneading the bedspread as another powerful climax erupted through her, starting from the searing connection between them, and the hard cock that now exploded deep inside her, pumping his cream inside her tight quivering heat.

And both of them were crying out together, their rhythm perfectly synchronized, their orgasm shared and more than the sum of its individual parts.

“Hell of a crime lab,” he heard her whisper, but had nothing in his tank with which to offer a reply.

Five

It always slightly unnerved him to see Detective Inspector Mulray, even as attractive as he found her. The simple fact that she was an officer of the law gave her the intimidation factor, something she probably would never entirely shake off until she stopped being a detective at all.

His first feeling, it seemed, was to wonder what he’d done wrong, and for what she might want to arrest him and sling him into jail.

She did probably have the power to cause him some real trouble, if she ever wanted to throw the book at him for meddling in the Hotel Killings investigation, or the hunt for the Black Widow as the papers were now unanimously describing it. He had to say quietly to himself that she herself could be linked to his activities, since she’d introduced him to Lily Foster, and she was now quietly introducing Emma to Martin Sallow’s best friend.

Exiting the drab concrete block of Kings College London’s Strand Campus on the Saturday afternoon, the unnerving way he felt on seeing DI Mulray was more to do with the fact that increasingly, she just seemed to know where he was at all times—to the point where he was certain it had to be the police who were following him, monitoring him.

“What are you doing here?”

She was standing by the curb as he walked out onto The Strand, in her standard suit, though this time her white shirt was buttoned all the way to the top.

“I should be asking you the same question,” she said, glancing up at the building. “I thought you were an Oxford man.”

Jonah said: “Needs must. Had to see a professor about my academic career.”

“Birds, wasn’t it? Or climate change.”

“Both, as it happened. Probably not any more.”

“Climate change on hold, I read in the papers,” Mulray impressed him, somewhat, in saying that.

He didn’t see her car anywhere, but as he turned left on The Strand, she started to walk slowly with him.

He said: “There is a view that things aren’t quite as bleak as we thought, yes.

Something about the oceans absorbing more of the carbon dioxide than models predicted... it’s not why I’m looking for a new direction.”

Mulray said: “You’ve been through a major psychological trauma. Something like that is going to affect anyone.”

It was uncanny how well she read him. He said: “Anyone would probably see my little research project about our feathered friends as fairly trivial if they had their brother murdered.”

“You can’t go on some kind of sabbatical?”

“I’m on sabbatical, officially. But a guy on sabbatical has to wonder what he’s doing after the sabbatical.”

“You can’t just relax, let yourself recover?”

He smiled, “Not the way my brain works, unfortunately. Can you just relax and talk to us next-of-kin when the police have something to tell

us?”

She gave a touché kind of a shrug. “I’m supposed to remind you not to talk to the press,” she said. It crept him out slightly, of course, though it wasn’t her fault.

“So your colleagues are watching me?”

She sighed. “They were watching Lily last night. Got a tip that the Gentlemen of the Press were getting interested in her relationship with the close relative of another of the Black Widow’s victims, so they just wanted to make sure she was all right.”

“I never knew Her Majesty’s Coppers were so thoughtful.”

“It’s a fairly complicated investigation,” she said. “It’s probably not the way things are normally done, but we need to make sure things don’t get out of control here.”

With Jonah leading their little perambulation, they passed a Pret a Manger sandwich shop and veered left at the intersection, heading for Waterloo Bridge.

“So if I told you there are men following me sometimes, would you relax and assume it was just a patrol of detectives checking that things aren’t getting out of control?” he asked. “Or would you think perhaps I need a little protection myself?”

“You have proof you’re being followed?”

“Well, that’s the problem, isn’t it? I have a corroborating witness, but he’s probably not going to want to get involved.”

She said: “I can see about getting a detail put on you, if that’s what you want.

Might not be so good if you wanted to... well, see certain people that my superiors preferred you didn’t...”

“That’s got to be the way, hasn’t it?” he nodded. “Well, you can tell your buddies that I’ve been suitably warned. Not that you guys really can stop me exercising my right to free speech.”

“Not without wasting a ton of resources.”

“He just gave me a lift, that was all. It was raining.”

“And you just sat there in silence with him, all the way to where, West India Quay?”

“Shoreditch. I went to find you guys,” he said.

There was a fresh breeze blowing off the Thames, but at least the sky was clear this evening, no rain. The light was quite beautiful as the sun began to dip down over Westminster. The Kinks had sung about sunset from this bridge, and both Constable and Monet had painted it, though the present incarnation was only notable for its view.

“He had some interesting ideas about Lord Moss,” Jonah said, feeling somehow safer in their conversation as they ventured out over the bridge. The exposure to the wind making it feel as though their conversation was lost to outside ears.

“You think it’s a good idea going there?” Mulray said, looking genuinely concerned. It was fair to say there was something anti-establishment in her mix, the way she had dealt with Jonah and his need to meddle. But even she knew a line had to be drawn somewhere.

“Julian Foster visited Lord Moss quite a few times in the months before he died.”

“And that was based on whose evidence?”

“A neighbor, supposedly. But I know for a fact they definitely met. There’s interview transcripts in Julian Foster’s office—he wrote the basis for Lord Moss’s obituary.”

“I guess we’ll have to take a little look at those,” she said.

“I think Julian Foster was writing a book about people who use the adult dating website my brother was using.”

“A book?”

“I don’t know if it was going to be a novel, or some kind of treatise on it all, but it’s possible he met or messaged Nate as part of that. We still have to check in Julian Foster’s account, it might all be there...”

“And you think he spoke to Lord Moss for the same reason?” Her tone suggested she knew why that sounded ridiculous.

“The reporter said Lord Moss was impotent.”

“I’ve heard something to that effect.”

“But maybe he had something else to do with that website. I don’t know... he invested in it, or he knew people who used the website.” He didn’t really want to suggest the idea that Julian Foster might be writing about wife-sharing, not yet.

Mulray knew a lot about Lily Foster, but he needed to talk to Lily before discussing that aspect of all this.

“You know we’re not really allowed to go near the Lord Moss stuff,” she said with some regret.

“No,” he said. “But it’s beginning to look as though it’s all linked in. Emma said Martin Sallow and his mates were using the No Strings website too, huh.”

Mulray nodded. “It’s back on the police agenda. Not publicly, of course.”

“Of course.”

In the middle of the bridge, Mulray came to a stop. “Be careful when you’re dealing with him,” she said, and Jonah turned back to her, seeing that she did not mean to accompany him to the South Bank.

“I’ll be careful.”

“He might seem friendly,” she said, “but he’s still Press. He’s not bound by solid standards.”

“I’ll be careful, Detective.”

She nodded, “I’ll be seeing you, Jonah.”



On his way back to the apartment from the Canary Wharf Tube Station, he tried calling Lily again. He’d called her that morning, but hadn’t got through.

This time, he left a message, though if she was anything like him, getting messages from so many journalists wanting to do some kind of color piece on the Black Widow murders, she probably didn’t check her voicemail these days.

“I think Julian may have interviewed some of the other victims,” he said, not wanting to drop the words “Lord Moss” into the phone call considering the fact that GCHQ, the government’s creepy spy agency, was probably listening in, as it could for all UK telephone calls if you believed the media these days.

“But there’s a few other things I wanted to talk to you about,” he added. “Call me when you can.”



Emma had her own reasons for suggesting that Jonah meet Bethany for their next date in the Queen of Hoxton. Probably, it had been the first venue on the tip of her tongue when she’d last messaged the young wife.

After sprucing himself up, he caught a cab over there from Nate’s apartment, feeling the need to escape Saturday evening on public transport.

He was actually feeling a little more nervous about seeing Bethany again than for a normal date put together via the No Strings website. There was a certain pressure on him, knowing that she wanted him to be the first man, other than her husband, that she would ever sleep with. The first man ever to draw her out of her stable monogamy.

The cab dropped him off on the corner, and it was now almost dark outside. Yet with its black walls, it seemed darker inside the bar, before his eyes acclimatized.

The place was surprisingly empty, particularly for a Saturday night.

It meant that he spotted Emma almost immediately, sitting towards the back of the place. She looked good, of course, in a thin white dress with floral print, which looked a little more hipster than he might have expected from her, but still made her look intensely desirable.

He half wondered if she was trying to remind him, as she monitored him dating another woman, that she was better than anyone else he might meet. She was making a good case.

Sidling up to the bar in an attempt to conceal any hint of suspicion that he recognized Emma, or that anyone in that bar was there to oversee his date with Bethany, he almost missed the fact that Emma was not sitting alone at her table with her glass of chilled white wine.

None other than Detective Mulray was there with her, dressed down in a relatively casual charcoal gray jacket over a white blouse and jeans.

She raised a glass toward him as he flinched slightly on spotting her. Well, he was early. Chances were that Bethany wasn't there yet.

Mulray really did seem more and more like a stalker—and she really was becoming very chummy with Emma. What was going on with that?

He ordered a Pilsner at the bar, liking the quick service that the empty place allowed.

“Hey, it's normally busier in here, isn't it?” he asked the woman behind the bar.

The woman sneered, though it was clear it wasn't directed at him or his question.

“Media's saying the Black Widow picks up her victims in East London pubs, aren't they?”

He nodded sympathetically.

“I think it’s all a load of old tosh myself,” the barmaid added. “It’s some prostitute, isn’t it? Doing in her clients for the money.”

“Maybe, maybe,” he said, thinking it not worth arguing the point.

The beer was ice cold and slipped down his throat easily. When he turned, however, Mulray was there at the back sitting on her own. She beckoned him over, and with fifteen minutes to wait for Bethany to arrive, there was probably no reason not to.

“You’re here as well?”

“Oh, it’s my new favorite place in the whole of London,” she joked.

He could detect her signature cinnamon scent as he took his seat next to her, and it made him wonder what it was.

“Where’s your new best friend gone?” he asked.

“Restroom. She’s got to make sure she looks tip-top.”

Jonah felt something burning inside his stomach. Emma was meeting Clement this evening. He’d completely forgotten. Jesus. Wasn’t she supposed to be monitoring him on all these dates?

But of course, Bethany wasn’t really part of the investigation any more. She was

just a momentary little diversion.

“You were briefing her, on what questions to ask him?” he asked the Detective, putting two and two together.

“Well you know, there’s certain things he probably wouldn’t tell the police.”

They watched Emma return from the stairs that led down to the nightclub part of the place, and the restrooms. Now as he saw her, he realized that she hadn’t dressed up to impress him, not at all. She was all dressed up for somebody else.

He felt his insides throb slightly. His Emma, seeing another guy.

She didn't return to sit with them. Instead, she went to the bar to order another glass of white wine. A single guy walked in off the street, almost unnoticed to them except that he then walked directly over to Emma, and she turned to him to kiss him on both cheeks, her face breaking out into one of her dazzling smiles.

"You feel threatened by it?" Mulray asked him.

"A little."

"But you don't want her to stop?"

He shook his head, and watched Emma starting her date. Recognizing the way she looked at him, the flirtatious way she laughed at his jokes, smiled at him constantly, touched him occasionally as though she didn't know what affect that would have on him. Everything she'd done with him on their first date.

This time, though, he was a third party watching from afar.

He was stunned by how beautiful she was. How she moved, even simply standing there at the bar with that guy. She was graceful, elegant, yet with an underlying forwardness that suggested her sexual availability for this guy. The way she pushed out her chest, tucked her hair back around her ear, the way she smiled and laughed.

"What kind of a name is Clement, anyway?" he asked, not really thinking about what he was saying.

Clement seemed nice enough. He imagined Emma found him attractive with a broad smile showing white teeth. He was a fairly big guy, powerful upper body, small waist. Caramel skin and large brown eyes. Quick to laugh, it seemed, though not loud. They could hear Emma more easily than her date, though no specific words were decipherable.

The way she looked at him made Jonah's stomach fold up.

He had one of his hands on her hip, as though they were dancing, slowly leaning in toward Emma.

And he kissed her, gently.

Jonah felt all the oxygen in the room disappear. It was only brief, but she didn't deflect it, didn't object to it. She melted into it, a little. That beaming smile returned to her pretty face immediately it was over, hinting strongly that she'd enjoyed it, that she might want more before the evening was out.

Jesus. This was no role-playing. This was no imagining. This was so intense compared to what he'd experienced with Lily Foster.

It made his head spin.

"She wants you to be jealous, you know that?" Mulray said. "She wants to know you feel that."

"I do," he said, breathing out slowly, trying to keep calm.

"She wants to know she's more to you than just a friend with benefits. Only, she's worried you'll be scared off."

"Scared off?"

"That you'll think she's trying to get a ring out of you, or something." Mulray shrugged, as though she saw this type of thing all the time. Like she was some kind of Dear Abby.

"Wait," he said. "She's the one who's worried I'll be scared off by the idea of commitment? She's never held down a long-term relationship in her life."

The Detective slurped her cocktail, all the fruit and bits of plastic poking out of the drink making it difficult to drink in an altogether sophisticated manner.

She said: "She's an interesting one, isn't she? She likes that you see other women—so long as it's just for sex. But she's quite taken with this girl Bethany's story."

"She's been pushing me to see her again," Jonah said.

"She likes that Bethany's husband seems to love her so much, he wants her to experience other men. I guess she likes the idea of that happening to her, too."

Jonah swallowed. “You seem to know a lot about her.”

“She needed someone to talk to,” the Detective said. “Someone who wasn’t you.”

He saw Clement’s hand slide down Emma’s back. They were too close, weren’t they? This was their first date, this was too early on their first date. Was Emma simply trying to get a reaction out of Jonah? Maybe she was going to let him down gently.

But then she leaned in to kiss him again.

Jonah felt slightly queasy. And yet, oddly, he was hard as a rock.

His heart was thumping twice as fast as usual, his skin felt all clammy. And the desire he felt for Emma just then was like nothing he’d ever felt for any woman.

She was his, he wanted to swoop in and grab her, drag her back to his cave.

Remind her about certain things with an almighty orgasm or two.

It was, weirdly, unbelievably exciting to watch her flirting with another man, opening up to him, offering herself up on a plate to him.

And then another familiar face walked into the Queen of Hoxton, and Jonah had to try to snap himself out of his daze. Bethany was here. She was here, and looking gorgeous.

“That’s her?” Mulray asked, doubtless seeing clearly how he reacted to the newcomer.

He nodded.

Did Emma see her? His blonde particularly-personal assistant briefly turned to look in his direction, and flashed him a quick smile. It warmed him inside intensely. It said, in a matter of a split second, that she wanted to know if he was really all right with her seeing Clement that evening. That she knew he was about to see Bethany, that something might happen with Bethany and she was all right with it.

Jonah smiled back at her, hoping she read it as his consent to do as she wanted with her evening's date.

It made him feel as though he was walking out on a high tightrope by offering her that assurance. But how could he possibly deny her a little evening's fun, when she had been monitoring his attempt to sleep with half of London's available women as part of some ludicrous strategy to unveil a serial killer?

As Jonah rose to his feet to approach Bethany, Emma and Clement left the bar, destination unknown.

Six

"Is he going to follow us?"

"I think so."

She took Jonah's hand as they stepped out into the dark street, and he felt her slight tremble. Nervous. It was sweet, but along with the fact that she was in the process of seriously contemplating some kind of sexual engagement with him, Jonah found it arousing because Bethany was so obviously straying out of her comfort zone in the pursuit of carnal thrills.

"How are you feeling about all this?" he asked her.

"Scared," she said. "Excited too, but it's quite scary."

They walked away from the bar down an empty street that led through to office buildings that were mostly dark and dormant for the night.

"What is it that's scaring you?"

"I don't know," she shrugged. "I guess that we'll do something and Richie won't like it. Or that he likes it now, but then later on he changes his mind."

She looked in his face, and he saw a frightened little rabbit walking beside him.

The fire inside him saw cuteness, perhaps a hint of seductive vulnerability, the gentle color in her cheeks also suggesting desire. The

cool, responsible part of him knew he couldn't rush her into anything.

"We don't have to do anything tonight if you don't want to," he said. "We can just walk, talk. Go back to the pub, if you like."

She turned to look behind them, checking to see if anyone was following. Then she gave him a smile that was attempting to put a brave face on things. "Oh, I know," she said, "But it's not just what I want, you know."

She had a mischievous glint in her eyes at that, as though she could pin any blame for her misbehavior on her husband and his strange fantasy.

"Wait," she said, and tightened her hand in his to stop him.

He turned to her, and she put her hands over his shoulder, pulling him in for a sweet kiss. She tasted slightly of cherries, no doubt from her cocktail, while her sugary vanilla perfume added to the affect to swamp him with sweetness.

He sucked gently on her lips, and as she responded, slightly breathless, she let out quiet little moans.

Trailing slowly down her pale, velvet neck, so he could see her heaving chest, her nipples pushing against her thin dress, he noticed her glance down the street

—did she see him out there?

She was so pretty, those pixie freckles, her pale, sharp face, and those burning eyes. Richie must have been going crazy to see her making out with someone else in the street. And yet after everything Jonah had seen so far, he was curious as to how that felt.

It had to be beautiful to watch a girl like Bethany in the throes of passion. How incredible would it feel if you were in love with her?

The grin she gave him as he pulled back, his eyes clearly posing the question, confirmed that her husband was, indeed, watching her.

"We should go a little further," she breathed, "it's too exposed here."

Jonah nodded, his senses reeling a little, overloaded by her kiss, and let her drag him onward.

They turned a corner, and then another, ducking down an alleyway that made Jonah wonder if Richie would find it difficult to find them.

This was a pedestrianized area, an office building complex that seemed closed off, almost as though there was a roof over them. Most importantly, it was full of shade and shadows, nooks and dark corners, and plenty of shelter from the risk of discovery by others out on the street.

Bethany pulled him in for another kiss as they came to a doorway, and this time they both felt a little more confident with some distance between themselves and the road open to traffic.

Jonah slid his hand down her back, over the curve of her behind, making her giggle as she kissed him, cradling his head in her hands.

“He’ll be able to see?” he asked her.

“He’ll find us, don’t worry.”

Her dress was so soft, clinging to her curves. One of Jonah’s hands cupped her breast, and as she brought a hand over his, he thought perhaps he’d gone too far, she’d move his hand away. But she merely pressed his hand more firmly against her body, and offered him a wicked smile.

She wanted this, she really wanted this.

She’d talked with her husband for a long while about all this, taking it so steadily as she made absolutely certain this was what he wanted. Now it was here, and whether or not she fully understood her husband’s fantasies, the simple fact was she had an attractive guy in her clutches, and the green light to enjoy his attention.

He kissed her neck gently, inhaling her sweet scent, but now she turned in his arms, so that her back was to him, and both of Jonah’s hands could sweep over her curves and slide over her breasts, while she could reach behind her and feel out the shape of his hardness beneath his pants.

She laughed lightly as her fingers splayed over his cock, at his stiffness, at his size.

One of Jonah's hands trailed down her stomach to dip between her thighs, her dress allowing him some leeway to brush over her covered sex.

It was only a moment, then he was kissing the back of her neck, his hands cupping her breasts, then his fingers slipping in under the low neckline of her dress and under her thin bra to find those hard nipples of hers.

She moaned as he touched her hardened little buds.

“Oh God...”

And then she was turning to kiss him over one shoulder, smiling so broadly as he coaxed her breasts, and as she pushed the wonderful roundness of her behind back against his hard cock.

“You like being a bad girl?” he whispered to her, smiling.

“Absolutely,” she said, turning back to him, her hands stroking his cock now, and strongly desiring it. “But I like being a bad girl for my husband most of all.”

“Of course you do.”

She was so sexy, she seemed so very alive, her face so buzzed and alert, her broad grin showing plenty of pearly whites.

They kissed again, and this time her hands moved to his belt, fumbling to unfasten the buckle, and then release his fly button. She tucked her fingers inside his pants and underwear now that she'd loosened his waistband, then tugged it down just a little, to free his lurking beast.

As she first touched her fingers delicately against it, it made her gasp.

The way she explored it with her hands made him think she was impressed with it, but there was also the fact that this was the first cock she'd touched other than her husband's. Bethany had been with no other men but Richie.

There had been a time when Jonah had been uncomfortable with girlfriends having sexual pasts—the fact that they’d had sex before getting together with him. He’d even wondered at one point if he’d ever want to marry someone who wasn’t a virgin. He’d left that particular sentiment behind with his teenage years, but now he saw the thrill with which Bethany reacted to him, he felt differently about it. He felt certain he’d want his wife to have a wonderful sexual past—to have experienced what life had to offer.

Bethany at least had a husband who was willing to let her experience what life had to offer after the fact.

She beamed up at him as she now sank to her knees, and took his manhood in her hand.

“It’s so big,” she said, “so beautiful.”

“You haven’t seen too many,” Jonah couldn’t help but smile.

She shook her head. Then her eyes latched onto the head of his cock, and she brought it to her mouth, circling it around but only brushing her lips. She leaned in and touched her nose to the base of his shaft, then gently licked her way slowly up his full length, exploring him, examining him.

Where was Richie? Jonah couldn’t see anything out there, but there were so many places where someone could hide while still observing this little corner that it said nothing that he couldn’t see anyone.

Could he see his wife touching another man’s cock? Kissing its tip? Opening her mouth to take it inside...

Jonah groaned as he felt the intense wet heat of her mouth envelop his sensitive head.

She moved slowly on his length, but more from the fact that this wasn’t her husband she was tending to, and she seemed to want to experience this strange cock, take full advantage of her first break from monogamy. She took frequent pauses to lick and kiss his shaft or its head, pumping him with her tight grip, stroking him over her lips and even her velvet cheeks, indulging in this other man’s cock she had to play with.

It felt amazing, and dispelled any thoughts that she had little experience. Richie had to be a fully satisfied husband even if his fantasy was to share his pixie wife.

She was all smiles looking up at him, her pretty face so sweet in enjoying her depravity.

Jonah leaned down as she stretched up for a kiss, still on her knees, and as he kissed her he could reach down between her legs, drawing up the hem of her dress so that he could lodge his hand between her bare thighs, sampling the raw heat and moisture emanating from her underwear.

He knelt with her, kissing her cheek, under her jaw, and she moved his hand up under her dress to the top of her drenched panties, giving him the clear signal to slip his hand inside her underwear.

He felt the sprinkling of her pubic hair over her mound, and it seemed intensely exciting to him. Though he'd hoped for something with Bethany this evening, he hadn't expected to get this far. His fingers found the smooth heat of her pussy lips, quite astoundingly wet from her first brush with an open relationship.

Her hand gripped his wrist tight, locking him there so that he had no choice but to stroke her sex. With her other hand, she held his face as she gazed into his eyes with such an intent stare—marking the occasion of the first time she had been touched by another man in this way.

She rocked slightly as he stroked her, her breathing deepening by the moment, and when she kissed him again, it was almost a way to steady herself, to keep herself from falling over.

“Stand up,” Jonah whispered to her, taking a chance on how far she might let him go.

She looked a little confused at him, but complied, rising to her feet. He pressed his face into her stomach, feeling the heat through the material of her dress, but then pushing up the garment to reveal her white lacy panties and her bare midriff, so he could kiss her there without obstruction.

She smiled down at him as he breathed her in, his hands clutching the satisfying roundness of her behind, and she placed the hand not

supporting her against the wall on his scalp as he now drew her panties down her legs.

She wasn't stopping him, though Jonah got the impression she wasn't entirely sure what he was up to. She stepped out of her panties, tracing a rogue strand of her hair out of her face, behind an ear as she watched him.

How far did she expect to go on in this open alleyway? They hadn't really talked about limits.

In the half light, he glanced at her womanhood, with its cute little triangle of honey-colored down pointing down to her sweet lips. He kissed his way around it, and then through it, inhaling the delicate spice of her arousal as though it were some kind of narcotic.

Gently, he raised one of her thighs and guided her to lift it over one of his shoulders, allowing him to ease under her, and touch his lips to her sweet little

pink petals.

Looking up at her, offering her a reassuring smile, he saw how startled she appeared, almost astonished by what he was doing. Then his mouth touched down on her sensitive folds, and as his hot tongue emerged to course through her soaking lips, the astonishment melted from her face.

Trailing his tongue between her outer and inner lips, and then slowly through her hot, dripping slit, he smiled as he saw her tilt back her head, close her eyes and let out a long anguished groan as though he was itching a scratch that had remained untended for years.

He loved her flavor, its subtly compared to other women, the creaminess, the hint of sweetness along with the characteristic tang of womanhood.

He loved the silky sounds of her breathing, her quiet moans as he licked her, the deeper groans when he softly sucked on her clit.

He loved the way she began to fondle her own breasts as she let herself go with the sensations flowing through her body, the way her caressing of his head came to a halt so that she was simply holding onto him tight, clamping him against her succulent pussy while stirring her hips to fuck his mouth.

The whimpers, the trembles, the cries, the gasping for breath, the faint look of shock on her face as a sensational orgasm swept through her petite frame.

“Oh Jesus... Oh Jesus...”

The little flood of her sweet nectar as she came, too. He adored it all.

She slid down and urged him up again, saying: “He wants to see you come over me.”

“Over you?”

She smiled wickedly, and slipped the straps of her dress, and then of her bra off her shoulders, then pushing them down to expose her small but sweet breasts fully along with those stiff little nipples of hers. “Over my face and my breasts,”

she said. “He wants you to mark me. Make me dirty.”

Jonah felt he had so much more to learn about these wife-sharing fantasies. Each couple had their own little quirks, their own favored kinks.

Standing over her again, Bethany gave him a long lick along the underside of his cock from base to tip, then eased her mouth back over his cock head, seeming a little more accustomed to it this time.

She held the base of his cock in her cool hand, bobbing her head down his shaft a little further than before.

Jonah looked out into the shadows, and still could not see anyone watching.

She was touching herself, subtly, while she sucked on him, her spare hand there between her legs as she sat on her haunches, doing its own thing. Jonah found it intensely erotic that she was getting off on this, that she couldn't stop herself from slipping her fingers back inside her wet little pussy while her husband watched her sinking on another man's hardness.

But now it was time to let go. He felt the surge building deep inside his loins, and groaned a little louder than he might, in order to warn her what

was coming.

She grinned, and invited him openly by pushing back slightly, offering her bare chest and pale neck as a target. Still touching herself, her nipples jutting out, flushed with blood, she bit her lip in anticipation of his climax.

As it came, her hand dropped away to leave him holding his cock as it spasmed in his hand, shooting his thick white cream in streaks over her smiling mouth, her chin, and down over her breasts.

She was laughing, loving the seediness of it all, the depravity, the obscenity.

Rubbing his come into the skin of her breasts, licking her lips and then leaning forward to take Jonah's cock, to gently clean his tip with her mouth.

"God, that was wild," she purred.

"You really are something," Jonah said, out of breath, not quite knowing what to say to her.

They were calming down a little, and attempting to leisurely reassemble their clothes, when movement away and to the left made them both jump. A dark-

haired man in a black leather jacket and jeans careered around the corner.

Bethany looked up at him with an immediate and loving smile, but also a hint of fear at why this man might have approached them like this, at this point.

It wasn't difficult to work out that this man was the husband, Richie. But had he had second thoughts about this?

"Hey honey! Everything all right?" Bethany asked him.

Richie was a little breathless. He seemed happy, Jonah thought. Not in any way angry, anyway.

Then he said to Jonah: “There were two other guys, watching. You know about them?”

Seven

Jonah returned to the apartment feeling a little strange—elated, both about his evening seeing Bethany and oddly that Emma was currently out dating another man, Martin Sallow’s best friend. But he was also feeling unsettled, nervous.

And that came from Richie’s observation that he had been watched by two other unknown men while he’d been with Bethany. It also came from wondering how he would really feel about Emma when she came back from her date. If she’d gone through with it all, slept with another man.

He did feel a touch of jealousy that she was out with another man, that as he ascended the elevator to Nate’s floor and the apartment, she might be in bed with someone else, riding him like she had Jonah countless times before. But there was something weirdly exciting about that: to think of Emma being so naughty, to think of her really enjoying herself, satisfying herself with a stranger, that she might be doing it in part to make him jealous, to make sure Jonah valued her.

He felt the anxiety from the possibility that he might lose her—that she would think Clement better than him, and decide to leave him, or that she would return to him and find that he was not as jealous as she had hoped, and respond by leaving him.

He wanted to see her so badly, he wanted to rip off her clothes and make love to her wicked flesh, her sullied, dirtied body.

He wanted to feel the wild thrill he had been close to feeling watching Lily, and know for certain that Emma was someone he wanted to be with, even if they both continued to see other people.

It wasn’t fair, of course, that he should continue dating other women in the course of this investigation, and expect Emma to remain only his. The surprise, if anything, was that she hadn’t been dating other men since she first started seeing Jonah.

What if she stayed the night with Clement?

The thought made him feel faintly nauseous. Bizarrely, it did actually provoke a little tingle inside him, the excitement of facing a potential danger, the risk of losing her, but also the thought that if she stayed the night, she would definitely be sleeping with the guy. Definitely be testing their relationship to the limits.

Definitely be experiencing the thrill of a new man between her legs.

It felt like lining up to go on a ferocious roller coaster.

The phone was ringing when he arrived at the apartment front door and tapped out the code to let himself in. His mind wasn't really in the right place—it could have been anyone, even at that ridiculous hour. It could have been another journalist demanding to know what he thought about the latest murder, or whether he was dating Lily Foster. But wandering into that big place, he was distracted. He picked it up hoping it might be Emma, telling him she was on her way.

“Jonah?”

A man's voice. Jonah's hope turned sour.

“Jonah, is that you?”

He said, coldly, “It's me.”

“Jonah, it's Graham. You know, Used-To-Work-With-Nate Graham.”

Jonah felt his insides thaw suddenly, from the power of relief. “Oh, of course.

Sorry, Graham—I get a lot of reporters calling me these days.”

“I bet you do—I don't have your mobile number though.”

Odd time for Graham to call.

“Look, I'm sorry to call so late,” he said, acknowledging the elephant in the room.

“No, no, it's okay.”

“I’ve just... well... I’ve been thinking, and it’s kind of been messing up my sleep.”

“What is it?”

Jonah slumped down on one of the white couches, gazing out of the floor-to-ceiling windows over the water to the crisp straight lines of the office buildings of Canary Wharf and Cabot Square.

It had been a while since he’d seen Graham, over a drink at All Bar One on the other side of the wharf he was looking at now.

“After we spoke last...” Graham seemed to be finding it hard to get the words out. “...I was given some of Nate’s old accounts to sort out. They had me looking through his desktop...”

“Wait, the police gave you guys back his computer?”

“No... no, the company keeps a backup of everyone’s machine,” Graham explained. It made Jonah’s heart jolt. If he could get access to one of Nate’s computers, would there be any useful information stored on it? Like the log-in details for Nate’s account on the No Strings website.

“It’s just the account details, the transactions,” he went on, and Jonah felt fairly sure that would limit the possibility of unlocking Nate’s user name and password information. “You know, in case anything goes wrong with the technology—or if there’s something amiss with a trade somewhere.”

“Of course. So you found something in Nate’s computer?”

“Look,” he said, lowering his voice as though he might be overheard, even at this time in the dead of night. “It’s kind of against company policy to discuss any of this...”

“I won’t tell if you won’t.”

“And this line... it’s safe?”

Jonah’s ears pricked up. He said, “Safe? How d’you mean ‘safe’?”

“The police—they haven’t... well, tapped the line or anything?”

“No, not as far as I know. You’d have to get some kind of warrant to do, that,

right?”

He heard Graham breathe, long and slow, trying to keep himself calm while making the decision whether to potentially expose himself to the kind of danger that would put his livelihood at risk.

“Okay, so... this is nothing to do with that serial killer. I’m sorry, I know you’ve been hoping to figure that out...”

“It’s okay. Look, what’s this all about, Graham?”

“I just think... if any of this comes out, and it might come out one day... you just deserve to be... prepared for it.”

Jonah felt his stomach flip, and fill with dread. What had Nate been involved in?

He hadn’t really been ready to hear this kind of stuff. His search for his brother’s killer had taken the assumption that Nate had been whiter than white, the beloved brother he knew. An innocent slain for no good reason.

Had he been corrupted by the City?

“Before he died... it stretches back a while, I think, maybe a year, maybe two...

but in the last few months, particularly...”

“What did he do?”

“A lot of big-money trades. It started out fairly modestly by comparison, but by the end... well, let’s just say that if he’d lost that kind of money... I don’t think it was Nick Leeson level or anything. But he didn’t lose, they were all successful.”

“What’s the problem—he didn’t have the authority to do it?”

“According to the system, he did. He was authorized. But it just wasn’t... I don’t know... none of us knew anything about it. Nate certainly didn’t

talk about it—

and everybody talks about their big wins.”

“Who authorized these trades?”

“Selmer. He’s the boss—well, our boss’s boss, really. VP Western Europe. Two

steps up.”

“So it wouldn’t be Nate that would get in trouble, it would be him?”

“I suppose so. But... I don’t know, something about it is all wrong. I don’t know, maybe nothing will come of all this. I’m not going to tell anybody, report it to anyone. I just thought... well, in case you wanted to make sure you had a lawyer handy, or a good accountant.”

“You think they might come after Nate’s estate, if this was discovered?”

“I’m not sure. I mean, he didn’t lose the money. It seems against the rules, it’s too much money for our level, too much risk.”

“Thanks for telling me, Graham, I appreciate it. Look, we should grab a drink some time...”



He heard the electronic tones of the keypad as the code was entered to open the front door. It woke Jonah quite suddenly—and after the thoughts and dreams he’d had after slipping off to sleep, he woke with the feeling that the financial authorities were raiding Nate’s flat, that they were after any evidence that might have been left regarding Nate’s trading activity.

He felt a little stupid as he heard the door close, and then a few moments later Emma climbed onto the bed.

Jonah’s heart pulsed with fire. She was back from her date.

“Hey, sleepyhead,” she said softly, kneeling beside him before filling his face with hers, swamping him with her sweet coconut fragrance.

“Hey...” he said, dazed, turning his head to look at the bedside alarm clock, which stated the time as 2am. Her kiss hit his cheek instead of his mouth. “You just got back?”

He turned back into her kiss, tasting her mouth, detecting the sharp flavor of white wine, a Sauvignon Blanc no doubt.

“Are you angry with me?” she breathed in between kissing him delicately.

“For being out late?”

“For going out with another man.”

Jonah felt himself tremble with desire for this gorgeous girl at her confirmation that she’d spent all this time with another man. He felt a curious mix of emotions, but the overpowering sense he had was of some deep biological instinct to grab her, pull her over and then take her, hard.

His masculinity was threatened by her seeing another man, and his body was responding with a rush of testosterone.

He had to control it. It was quite a rush, however. More than he expected after his experience role-playing with Lily. Was this what had driven Julian to share his wife?

What a buzz.

“I’m not angry,” he said, slipping his tongue in her mouth, wondering how far she’d gone with Clement.

Emma was wearing her floral dress, but looking down her chest, taking in the pleasant view of her shapely breasts crushed against his chest, it seemed to him that she was no longer wearing her bra.

“How could I be angry at you, when I’ve been seeing a ton of other women?” he said.

She smiled, "I guess it is only fair. I just... didn't know how you'd feel about it.

I think a lot of men wouldn't be happy about it."

She kissed his chest, and Jonah slid a hand underneath her, down her dress, pulling the thing up a little so he could get his fingers underneath.

She wasn't wearing underwear.

"Did you go back to his place?" Jonah asked her, his fingers finding her hot flesh already slippery with her juices, and her sex itself absolutely dripping.

"We went to a hotel," she said.

Jonah shivered again at the knowledge that she'd been with Clement, slept with him. Fucked him. The jealousy coursed through his veins, but that caveman part of him responded with pure lust, pure desire. He was harder than he had ever been in his life.

As she kissed him now, he wondered if her mouth had taken another man's cock inside it earlier that evening. Strangely, it didn't put him off kissing her.

"Are you jealous?" she asked.

"A little."

"But you don't hate me, you're not angry?"

"Not at all. It's kind of hot, actually," he said, and felt her hand trailing down his

chest, his stomach, finding his huge erection.

"Jesus," she said, pulling her face back to look at him. He slipped a finger between her wet pussy lips, up to a knuckle.

"What?"

"You're turned on?"

“You have a problem with that?”

“No, of course not.” She kissed him again, and he slid the rest of his finger inside her. Had another man been inside her there? Another man’s hard cock?

Jonah felt so buzzed. He really wasn’t angry. It was a little unexpected, but somehow in his eyes, Emma was enhanced as a gorgeous, sexual being.

“Mulray said you might react this way,” she said, and Jonah felt himself effervesce slightly, to know that she had spoken so intimately about him with the attractive Detective.

“Since when did you two become best buddies?”

She smiled, and swung her leg all the way over him now, so she was straddling him, feeling his hardness though the bed sheet kept her bare flesh away from it.

“Since you stood me up that night in the Internet cafe so you could go see Lily Foster,” she said proudly.

“I was hardly standing you up. I seem to recall attending the date, if that’s what it was. I made you feel pretty good at the time, from what I remember.”

She giggled, “Oh, you did. But then you left me, and told me to go with her to see Martin Sallow’s sister with her.”

“His sister. I wasn’t expecting you to ask out his best friend. Mulray suggest that?”

Emma kissed him, hard, then grinned, “She said I should get you back. And then you were seeing Bethany again...”

“I thought you were all right about that. You were the one that set it up in the first place—and in the pub where Martin Sallow’s friends go.”

“I was all right about it. But Mulray said...”

“You wanted to make me jealous, and she told you to go out with Martin Sallow’s best friend?”

“Clement. He’s nice.”

“You fucked him?” Jonah’s heart was pounding. God, it was so exciting, to think she’d been so wicked, so depraved. That another man had wanted her so badly he’d taken her to a hotel.

“Does that horrify you?” she asked, holding the back of his head, kissing him forcefully as though to provoke him. “Does that disgust you?”

She was sitting on his hardness, feeling how he was responding to her, and it was clear to her that what she was saying was having a more than positive effect on him.

“It was so hot,” she said taunting him. “We got in the room and his hands were all over me...”

She rocked back and forth on his hardness, her breathing beginning to deepen.

He kissed her neck, and could have sworn he could detect the slight hint of male cologne, though she’d attempted to cover it up with a spritz of her perfume.

“Oh, and he’s a good kisser... better than I expected for a City boy...”

Jonah ducked under her, pushed down her dress, confirming the absence of a bra, taking her hard little nipple into his mouth to make her moan, to make her hand on his head tighten her grip.

“Then we were tearing our clothes off...”

“And you left half of them there?”

She giggled, “I guess I did, didn’t I?”

Jonah was elated, and it was as much about feeling his bond with Emma strengthen—that he wasn’t disgusted by her, he wasn’t furious with her, he only wanted her more, wanted her to be bad, wanted her to cheat on

him—as the fact that he got to have rampant sex with this gorgeous creature.

“Did you fuck him?” he asked.

“He had such a big dick,” she said, then let out a little squeal as Jonah grabbed the base of her buttocks and her upper thighs, pulling her hips so she knelt above his upper chest.

“Did you fuck him?” he demanded to know.

Her hands dropped to hold his shoulders, and she looked down on him with mild confusion as he kissed her stomach.

“I couldn’t help it,” she said in a small, soft voice, as though anticipating his rage.

He looked up at her. “Did you fuck him?”

“I fucked him.”

His grip on her behind tightened further, and he now lifted her onto his face, clamping his hot mouth to her soaking pussy. Tasting her insatiable sex.

She let out a breathy cry as his tongue slipped out to penetrate her, and clung on to the headboard of the bed. He’d never known her quite so wet. She was delicious.

“Oh yeah...”

“You liked his... he felt good?”

“He was... very large. When he put it inside me... God, I thought he was gonna split me open...”

Jonah felt a burst of adrenaline. He pulled her forcefully down on his mouth, devouring her. It seemed so wrong, another man’s cock had pushed its way inside his Emma’s pussy, and now he was licking her. But something about the

forbidden nature of it made him tingle all over, the blood rushing to his loins.

It felt like sex had been when he was a teenager—against the rules, and so very exciting.

“He made you come?”

“Yes. Was that bad?”

“No, no. I like that he did. And he came?”

“Yes.”

“Where?”

“Inside me.” He shivered, and not from revulsion, but she added: “I did take a shower before I came home, you know.”

Jonah relaxed in the pillows now, lying flat on his back, Emma sitting astride his face as he continued to feast on her exquisite pussy. God, did he love this girl?

He adored her, certainly. Could he be in love with her, if he was so apparently happy for her to find pleasure in other men as well?

“What about you and Bethany?” Emma said, finding it a little hard to speak distracted by her eager lover. “Did you go through with it?”

Jonah pulled her tight against his mouth for a moment, then broke free. “We just went for a walk,” he said.

“That’s all?”

He looked up at her and smiled, “We did play around a little.”

“You got a hotel room?”

“No, we found a quiet doorway.”

She looked down at him, “And how far did you go?”

“It was a lot like this, actually,” he said.

She grinned, “You are a hungry boy. I bet she enjoyed it. Her husband—Richie

—he was watching?”

“He was.”

“God that must have been wild for him. And you didn’t do anything else?”

Jonah said, “She went down on me, too.”

Emma’s eyes seemed to light up at that. “Lucky girl, I bet she loved that.”

The pretty blonde leaned back, giving him more of a view up her body and a little more air, and she reached for his erection, pushing the bedsheets away to expose it to her gaze.

Then she hopped off his face, which was something of a disappointment until she turned around and remounted him, backing up her rear to once again present her soaking pussy for his enjoyment. This time, he felt her hair drape over his loins and her hands bring his hardness up to her mouth.

She giggled as she took him into her hot mouth, and then moaned as he resumed his devouring of her sensitive sex.

Could he detect the slight tang in her nectar that hadn’t been there before, the hint of a condom? It seemed so wrong, and yet he found himself imagining that this sweet pussy had taken another man inside it, and it only turned him on.

Was he really happy for Emma to continue dating other men? Strangely, he was.

There was something exciting about it. He’d get to hear about her experiences.

He thought she came, there on his lips, but Jonah did not want to come in her mouth. If another man got to penetrate her, he was certainly going to match him.

He urged her over, and Emma willingly turned onto her back, allowing him to line up between her thighs.

“What was she like?” Emma asked him as he pressed his hardness down over her open pussy.

“Well, you’ve seen her.”

“Not like you’ve seen her.”

“She was pretty, sweet, a lovely girl. What do you want to know?”

“You enjoyed her?” Emma asked.

“I did.” He held her legs open, brushed the end of his cock around her slippery folds. “She was really nice, what can I say?”

“I bet she enjoyed you. And Richie was watching the whole time?”

“He was.”

“What was that like?”

“Okay.”

“Okay?”

Jonah touched the tip of his cock to the centre of her heat, and now pushed forward, making her gasp as he slid inside her.

“I think the way it made her respond was pretty hot,” he said. “I think I could see the appeal in that.”

“It didn’t put you off?”

Emma groaned as he began to move inside her, forcing his hardness into that tight little channel, feeling her squeezing him, so slick and hot around him. His cock felt like granite pushing into her, her legs splayed so wide—the second time that night she’d spread them for a man.

“Not as much as I thought it would. I met him.”

“Richie?”

“Afterwards. He came over.”

“What was he like?”

“Nice guy. She totally adores him.”

“Of course she does,” Emma smiled up at him. “He loves her so much he lets her play with other men.”

The way she was smiling at him suddenly made Jonah feel that she wasn’t just talking about Bethany. The intense affection, the adoration, warmed his entire body—God, no wonder men like Richie were so willing to let their wives play freely. The way it must make their wives feel about them...

Or was he just imagining that Emma felt that way about him? She wasn’t the type to fall in love, was she? So young and carefree.

“When he came over,” he said, “Richie said there were two other guys watching us. He saw them.”

“Jesus. He knew them?”

“No. I think it was the guys who’ve been following me.”

“Shit, and that was proof. Who are they?”

“I don’t know. I need to talk to Mulray about it. Now I know I’m not imagining it all. Did he use a condom when he...”

She shook her head, and paused to see how he’d react. He must have been imagining the hint of a condom in her flavor—but then, his imagination was running wild here. To think she’d had him inside her, bareback. A huge bare cock using this sweet little pussy.

He leaned forward, grabbed her breasts and pounded into her. She was his, but she’d been so very wicked, giving herself to another man. His body, his manhood, just reacted with furious desire. His instinctive need to reclaim her.

There was a huge great smile plastered all over her face as he fucked her. As though he’d just passed some kind of relationship test.

“He... uses the... No... Strings... website...” she said, breathless as he plunged into her over and over.

“Martin Sallow?”

“Clement.”

He pulled off her, and now turned her over, urging her onto all fours before stroking his cock gently against her wet folds once again, holding onto her lower back and then easing inside her.

Supporting herself on her elbows, she let out a long, loud moan as he filled her completely.

“Showed me his health certificate and everything,” she said, explaining the lack of a condom. “Seemed like a lot of them were using it.”

“Interesting. I guess it’s what we thought, then.”

Then she was lying almost flat against the bed on her stomach, with Jonah straddling her thighs, continuing to thrust inside her, her pussy tight as a vice with her legs together. He lay over her and held her close, his hands slipping around her to cover her breasts, his face nuzzling into her neck and her clean-smelling hair.

This felt like truly reclaiming her, his wicked, wonderfully insatiable blonde.

He did actually want her to date other men: he knew that now. To be free to see who she wanted, but come back to him afterwards, to share the experience, to strengthen their bond with it.

It had surprised him how incredible it actually felt to know she’d been with another man, to let his body react naturally in its severe desperation to mate with her in order to dislodge another man’s seed.

It felt like riding on the edge, like extreme sports, like a death-defying roller coaster.

But when he came inside her, and she came with him, both of them rocking and writhing in that bed, singing sweet Hallelujahs as he filled

her with his hot oil, it seemed to Jonah, at least, that she was his once more, and that he wanted her above all else.



They slept, and only when they woke did he remember to tell her about the phone call with Graham.

Emma was in the shower already, getting ready for another day at college. She didn't seem to mind him wandering in to watch her soaping herself all over.

"You can't think he was doing anything wrong," she said immediately, springing to the defense of his brother.

"I don't think I do."

"He had authorization. He wasn't doing it alone." Her eyes urged him to join her, and he didn't need much persuading.

"No, he wasn't alone with it."

"And it's not like he would have told you anyway—he didn't talk to you about his work, did he?"

He kissed her, and somehow as her hands touched his face and she responded to his kiss, her tongue slipping into his mouth, it felt different. It was the realization, the confirmation in his own mind that she was more than just a date to him, more than just a friend with benefits.

"Not really," he said, his hands running down the slippery curves of her body.

"He told me general stuff. Where he worked, the people he worked with. Not so much the actual trading."

"So, then." Still kissing him, she gripped his cock, began to slowly pump it as it reached full hardness.

"I mean, that would have gone against company rules anyway."

She nodded. Then she looked at him with a hint of trepidation in her eyes.

“Would you be angry at me if I told you I might not have been entirely truthful last night?”

“Depends on how untruthful you were.”

His heart rate picked up. What had she lied about? And what could it be, that she was now nervous about telling him? That she wanted Clement, and not him?

That was about the only terrible thing Jonah could imagine.

“I didn’t do anything with Clement last night,” she said.

“Oh. Seriously?”

Another small nod. “I mean, we did go on a date, we did kiss at the end of it...

but that was it. I made up the rest.”

He raised his eyebrows. Emma still seemed nervous.

“I was trying to get you going,” she said. “And maybe... maybe see how you really feel about me, and what you would think about me... you know, seeing other guys.”

“I never said you couldn’t see other guys,” he said, confused.

She held onto his hardness again, almost apologetically. “I don’t know... I guess I wanted what Bethany has... and Mulray said...”

“Mulray put you up to this?” his question sounded a touch more irate than he meant.

“I don’t know... she warned me not to get involved with you unless I knew what I was getting into. I told her we were just fooling around.”

“Okay... I guess we are, right?”

“She said I’ve been standing by while you see other women, but not all guys would be happy for their girl to see other guys...”

“So you thought you’d test me?”

She pumped his erect cock, the hot water continuing to pour down over them.

“I wanted to see how you’d react to it, knowing I’d been with someone else.”

“And did I pass the test?”

She shrugged, “I was kind of surprised it turned you on so much.”

He turned her around, and Emma allowed him to manhandle her. To position her, bend her over. She groaned as he lay his cock between her buttocks, and then slid up inside her hot, wet pussy.

“So where does it leave us?” he asked her. “You still want me?”

“Of course,” she said, grunting as he filled her. “More than ever. If you still want me.”

“More than ever,” he agreed, panting as he took her from behind. “You know I’m not going to stop my investigation, right? That I need to see other women...”

“Oh, that’s okay, I like it,” she smiled, looking back at him over her shoulder.

“Can’t you tell?”

He laughed, “You’re always fascinated to hear about it afterwards.”

“I love it.”

“And you’ll see other guys if you want to.”

She moaned, panting as he fucked her. “And you’ll be all right with that?”

He turned her around, to face him, and she lifted a leg to allow him to reenter her. He looked her in the eyes, feeling that some kind of threshold was being crossed. He wanted her so badly, and yet he was going to tell her it was okay to see other men.

It felt so strange. She was unlike any girl he'd ever met, completely out of kilter from his sheltered academic world back in Oxford. And yet he loved it, he was obsessed by it. He wanted her to be bad.

"I want you to see whoever you want," he said, and it felt almost as though he was jumping out of an airplane, a parachute strapped to his back but no 100%

guarantee that it would open.

"But if you see other men," he added, "you have to tell me about it. Fair's fair."

"Fair's fair," she grinned, looking like the cat that got the cream.

"Are you going to see Clement again?"

"Murray thinks it would be useful."

"I'm sure she does," he chuckled. "Can't help but feel like we're her puppets, somehow. You think you will sleep with him?"

She nodded, "I think so."

And with that, he was shooting inside her, unable to hold back.

Eight

Tuesday night brought Jonah to a bar-restaurant on Shoreditch High Street by the name of The Light Bar, not far from Liverpool St Station and only a stone's throw from the Queen of Hoxton. It might be mid-week, but Jonah was wondering if the latest murder was now having an impact on the social life of the city of London.

From the moment he'd turned up at this smart converted industrial building, he'd felt it was a lot less crowded than perhaps it ought to be.

And even in the relatively short time he'd been here already, he felt certain the numbers of customers had dwindled even further.

The venue upped the volume on the acid jazz as if to plead with its clientele to make a night of it—or cover for the damage to the ambience that emptiness could cause.

Emma had arranged a date with a woman named Kaia, who was, according to her profile on No Strings, married with a husband who wanted her to go out and play.

When she'd arrived, she'd certainly appeared as attractive as her profile picture.

On first glance, she was about 25 years old, he would have said, with her Chinese ancestry providing long dark hair, styled straight and flowing down to her shoulder blades. She was pretty, and quite startling in a bright red dress, over which she wore a somewhat incongruous black leather jacket. It gave her a vampish look, along with her slightly goth-like eye make-up.

Initially, he would have thought Emma had done well, and not for the first time did he get the impression she'd chosen his date to make sure he had a good time and had plenty to talk about when he came back to her. But it was also no doubt true that Nate would have gone for attractive women, the chances were that the Black Widow was on the good-looking side if his brother had gone through with the date long enough for it to turn dangerous.

But their initial introduction had been a trifle awkward. He'd been through that before on these dates, but not quite like this.

Almost immediately, he'd offered to go and get the drinks, if she'd like to find a table. She'd looked at him as though he was about to run away and hide—and it was half-tempting just from that awkwardness. But he might get a one-star rating from her at the end of the night, and he didn't want to blot his copybook at this stage.

As he fetched the drinks at the bar, he did notice the proportion of men in the place was perhaps lower than normal. A lot of the customers who were in here were women.

Were London's men really being put off from bars and pubs by suggestions that they were at risk of a female serial killer? Perhaps it was only the places around here.

London was a city that was not as accustomed to homicide as American cities—

or cities in the movies—and even less accustomed to serial killings, though its history included more than a few notorious fiends. But even with an active serial killer now targeting male victims, the chances of any one guy becoming a victim were still astronomical in a city this size.

It reminded him of all those agonizing thoughts that had whirled around his head in the weeks and months following Nate's death. Why Nate? Why his brother?

Out of all the millions of men in London, why did it have to be Nate?

He was getting better at clearing his head of such thoughts now, though it was always going to be more difficult to rid himself of the constant ugly feeling of guilt that it had been his brother taken by the Black Widow, somehow, and not himself.

Before picking up the drinks, he paused a brief moment and took a deep breath.

Well, he'd be polite, at the very least. Perhaps they wouldn't have the chemistry, perhaps they could opt to terminate this date by mutual consent.

Hey, perhaps with a few drinks running through their frames, the ice would be suitably broken.

But perhaps not.

As he arrived at the table, Kaia's eyes flicked down to attempt some sort of assessment of his physical potential, though exactly how obvious his package was in the suit he was wearing was not clear to Jonah.

"Service is still pretty terrible in here then," she said as he handed over her Southern Comfort and Coke, "Even though it's half-empty."

“They downsize the workforce in here to match the demand,” Jonah said, channeling his inner City boy. “Classic retail response to economic conditions.”

Kaia said: “I bet you say that to all the girls. So what do you do? You’re in the City, right?”

“Trading—shares, investments, that kind of thing. How about you?”

“I’m a teacher.”

“That must be rewarding.”

“Rewarding like hives.”

Close up, he was definitely still attracted to her physically. She had a lean, willowy figure, with lightly golden skin, long glossy black hair sweeping down one side of her head to reach her cleavage, half-shielding one of her sharp, deep-brown eyes, which were emphasized with that overly heavy black liner.

She wasn’t a goth, he would have said, but she appeared influenced by that particular breed, her leather jacket and Doc Martin boots seemingly trying to send up the saccharine femininity of her startlingly bright scarlet dress, while her attitude took on the hint of sourness that goths seemed to make their own. Her accent was pure middle class, making him suspect that when she was being a teacher during the week, she probably toned down the whole attitude thing.

“So what do you do other than meet sleazy women in bars?”

“I... uh... play golf.”

He tried to recall some of the details of the ‘Robert’ persona he was using for these dates—normally, the women didn’t ask a huge amount about the intricate details of his day-to-day life, so he hadn’t really had to use the fiction too much.

The usual way was a brief smattering of small talk, and perhaps some conversation about some random topic as a distraction from the process of deciding whether the other person was suitable for the next stage, the more physical part of the date.

Now Kaia was asking him about himself, and in such a direct way, Jonah suddenly felt he needed to do some more research about the Robert character.

“Golf. You like that? Seems like a complete waste of time.”

“There’s a lot of skill involved.”

“You want to sink balls into holes, just play pool. Get it over with.”

“You’re not the sports type, I’m guessing.”

“Don’t see the point.”

“You’re more into... what, pulling the wings off butterflies? Spitting at homeless people.”

Well, if the date was going to turn to crap, why not?

But she actually smiled at that, and through her caustic outer shell, she had a pretty smile, too. For Jonah, it felt like a reward for his patience.

“I like music,” she had said, and perhaps confirming his fears, her body language shifted subtly, somehow opening, as though she was considering giving him a chance here. “Music and sex.”

She’d shot him a dark, fiery glance at that, challenging him to cope with her independent spirit.

“So we have something in common,” he’d returned, trying to think how Nate might reply to such a statement, while also doing his best to maintain a cool, almost blasé response to her implanting the connection between herself and sex into their conversation.

If Nate had gone for girls like this, he could see why. Even if he wasn’t hunting a killer, there was an edge to Kaia that seemed dangerous—her tongue could lash

him at a moment’s notice, ridicule any little thing he did with cruel but calm wit.

Yet she was also, without question, a stunning, sexually charged creature.

“You’re not wearing your wedding ring,” he said, voicing the thought as soon as it came to him.

“My husband likes me to take it off when I’m out by myself.”

“He doesn’t want people to know you’re married?”

“He likes feeling the risk.”

Jonah nodded. “And do you often give him cause for feeling there’s risk?”

She shrugged, and something about her hesitation suddenly made Jonah suspect that actually, she hadn’t done this too many times before.

“I don’t disappoint, if that’s what you mean,” she glanced at him, from the corner of her eye, as though testing out her continued ball-busting attitude. There was a softness underneath her hard shell, Jonah could tell. It made him a little more interested in her, but it also made him feel the likelihood that she was the killer diminishing.

Was he wasting time by continuing this date, if he started believing she wasn’t the one? Would she feel bad if he excused himself? It was only supposed to be a one night stand anyway, and these No Strings affairs were never guaranteed.

On the other hand, it seemed as though there was a kind of challenge here, to break down her tough outer shell. And the fact that Kaia wasn’t the normal type of woman he’d ever date, or see socially, interested him.

The few women he’d dated at Oxford had generally been from his own academic world, mousey girls with the kind of academic timidity toward the whole physical attraction thing that suggested responding to the body’s innate need for connection was somehow a betrayal of the progress made by human scholarship.

Kaia, on the other hand, pushed out her chest to flaunt her cleavage, unfazed by the fact her hard nipples were so defiant through her lace bra and the thin fabric of her bright dress.

This Internet dating business could turn up the most random of possibilities, though the No Strings site itself was geared up so that all

who used it at least had one driving force in common.

After a while, and a couple more drinks, their conversation did seem to flow a little more easily. And he even started to think that she was looking at him as though she might find him attractive—which made him entertain distinct possibilities.

“You been on many Internet dates before?” she asked him at one point, and Jonah couldn’t quite read her sharp look—was she impatient to get out of there, get to the sex stuff, or was she ridiculing him for online dating?

“A few,” he said, taking a sip of his gin and tonic, trying not to react physically to his drink’s bitterness, give the game away that it was merely part of his

‘Robert’ act.

“Why do you feel the need? You must get the occasional interest from women in bars...”

Jonah ignored her mild put-down. “It’s something different, you know? You don’t get the predictable types that hang around bars.”

“Married women? Must be plenty of married women like me hanging out in the right places, waiting to be picked up?”

“I like more certainty than that.”

“You ever had someone call it off? Stand you up?”

“Couple of times.”

“Did it bother you?”

“A little. But you can’t take it personally. Who knows why they didn’t show?

Maybe they couldn’t get a cab. Maybe their grandmother died.”

“Maybe hubby chickened out,” she said, making him wonder if her husband had done exactly that to her before. “Don’t you feel like a dork,

though? Using a website?”

Jonah smiled. “Everyone’s doing it these days. It’s mainstream. You’re doing it.”

“The husband set this up. We tried having me hang out in bars, pick up whatever flotsam or jetsam drifted by—but you know. More difficult than you think to find non-creeps for sex, huh.”

“So there you go.”

“Still seems like you’re admitting you’ve failed.”

“Is that how you feel right now?”

“I don’t care right now—I just want sex.” She jutted out her breasts again as though inviting his eye to run over her shapely figure, to check out the shadows of her black lace bra and imagine what else she could offer under that flimsy dress of hers. A twinkle in her eye and the resolute togetherness of her lips appeared to challenge him to sleep with her.

There appeared to be a question in her expression, and he couldn’t tell whether she was silently asking if he was man enough to sleep with a woman so brazen and headstrong, someone who wasn’t making it easy for him to hold a conversation. Or was she questioning his desire for a person of another race?

“You’re not looking to find The One, then—through this website. If you go for married types.”

“No. And it’s not that kind of website. One night stands, that’s the main thing.”

Jonah’s desire for this girl was not at issue at all. What was at issue was his sense that she was not a habitual user of the Internet for dating, which somewhat ruled her out of his inquiry.

“Doesn’t it feel a little shallow, though? Empty? If you know you’ll never see them again.”

Jonah shrugged. “Depends who you meet. Just because it’s no strings, doesn’t mean you definitely don’t get to see them again.”

“You seen anyone more than once?”

“A couple of them, yeah. “

“Because you fancy them?”

“Because I enjoy spending time with them. Because I learn a lot when I’m with them. Well, I guess I learn a fair bit with any date.”

“Learn? Learn what?” She peered at him, those dark eyes skirting over his face.

It seemed to Jonah that somehow he was interesting her. Like he had more to offer her than just sex.

He smiled. “You know—about what I like. What turns me on.”

“And what do you like?”

Jonah felt himself blush. Kaia noticed his hesitation. She said: “Go on—we’ll never see each other again, right? So what’s the harm in telling me?”

“I suppose.”

“Go on—tell me about your hottest date. Then I’ll tell you mine.”

He smiled—he was actually having a good time here. But he still had to be careful, he knew. Kaia’s derogatory view of Internet dating might actually lend her more credence as a suspect, not less, if you thought about it a certain way. If the killer was punishing men she considered losers for this manner of finding women for sex.

He ducked his head slightly, and although no one was particularly close to them in the bar, and certainly wasn’t close enough to hear, he said under his breath:

“One woman tied me up once.”

Kaia rolled her eyes. “Tied you up? That’s the big secret? I tie men up all the time. I tie the husband to the sink when the dishes need doing.”

“She tied me up and used me to get off—and then she left.”

Kaia shrugged. “Doesn’t sound that great to me—she didn’t want to fuck you?”

“I don’t know—I think she might be building up to it.”

“You think she’ll ask you out again?”

“That was our second one. The first time I just... you know... went down on her.”

He did notice some kind of glint in Kaia’s eyes at that.

“So you must be good at that then, she asked you back for another go,” she said, and he caught the impression she was trying to appear calm and unflustered.

“You like it? Doing that?”

“Of course,” Jonah said, feeling the alcohol beginning to let his inhibitions fly.

“Who wouldn’t?”

“Most of the guys I’ve dated,” she sighed. “Before I got married, that is.”

“Okay, your turn.”

“My turn?”

“What was your hottest date?” he asked her.

But Kaia was already up on her feet. “Come on—let’s get out of here. I’ll tell you later.”



They took a cab up past Angel into Islington, and Jonah found himself wondering whether they were headed for another bar or somewhere else.

They hadn't talked about a hotel yet—and this time Jonah hadn't booked a room, hoping to wing it if that particular opportunity arose.

“So let me get this straight—you never tried bondage before you started this whole sex website thing?”

“Never. I didn't try a lot of things.”

“And you prefer being tied up, or tying up the girl?”

“I... don't know, actually.”

Kaia said: “Okay, does the thought of me tying you up and doing whatever I want to you turn you on more than you tying me up and doing whatever you want to me?”

They were getting some odd glances from the cab driver through the mirror.

Jonah didn't care—he was laced with booze, and it turned out that he liked talking about risqué things with this hot Asian girl.

“I guess the thought of you tying me up.”

“If you could tie me up, and do whatever you wanted to me, what would you do?” She seemed to be having a good time talking candidly with him, too.

“I don't know... I guess I'd take off your clothes...”

“And if I was naked already?”

“Maybe kissing to start... if you wanted...”

“You're so submissive. Classic.”

“Is that a good thing?”

“Oh, totally. You're a valuable commodity. Hubby will be so pleased.”



It wasn't a bar they were going to. The cab dropped them off in a residential street full of little brown-brick row houses.

Kaia showed him into one of them, and up two flights of stairs to a little flat.

"Okay," she said, directing him into a little bedroom. "Take your clothes off and lie on your back on the bed—I'll be along in a minute."

Jonah felt more drunk than he'd ever been on a date before, but as he did as he was told and began to unfasten the buttons on his shirt, he felt seriously turned on.

Kaia was gorgeous, that was for sure. It wasn't just that she was attractive, or seemingly somewhat athletic—she had a seriously sexy attitude. And now that she'd effectively diagnosed him as submissive, it kind of made sense.

He removed his shoes and saw from the alarm clock on the bedside table that it was gone midnight—had they really been drinking that long?

Even with all the booze inside him, Jonah felt a little reluctant to remove his boxer shorts. He'd only just met this girl, and she'd spent half the evening telling him what a loser he was for online dating.

But, the hope of pleasing Kaia sufficiently for her to tend to the significant sexual craving he was feeling for her was stronger than his fear of humiliation.

He slipped his underwear off, and sat on the double bed, moving into the middle to lie as she had asked.

It was a fairly ordinary room for a youngish married couple. Blandly decorated with a couple of small Matisse prints on the wall, all fairly bright and breezy. No hints of the goth stuff.

He had a little time to think before she walked into the room, barefoot now, though still wearing her scarlet dress.

“Are you hungry?” she asked him, and he wasn’t sure whether she meant figuratively or was actually offering him food.

“Only for you,” he said, feeling a little self conscious to be lying there so exposed.

Did she like what she saw?

She smiled. “Good, ‘cause I’m not really one for fixing sandwiches. Or any food that’s not immediately edible once you’ve got the plastic unwrapped.”

She approached him, stooping to pull out the drawer in her bedside table. His gaze dwelled on her dress, which clung to her body so tightly, the bright material light enough to see her black lacy bra underneath, though it didn’t appear to show her panties—was she wearing any?

Then the glint of silvery steel caught his attention.

“Here,” she said, “these are for you.”

He felt himself tingling all over as Kaia put out her hand to silently demand his wrist. The handcuffs were cold, hard. Seemed like proper handcuffs, too—not your fluffy sex shop kind.

She walked around the bed to shackle his other wrist, and his eyes followed her as he tried to tell if she had indeed removed her panties.

Then his legs were shackled, the iron bedstead proving perfect for the task of holding him—and giving him the impression that was exactly why she had it.

“Comfortable?” she asked him, now walking around to his side again.

“Absolutely,” he said.

“Not too comfortable, I hope,” she said, and with that she climbed up onto the bed—and stood over him, one foot either side of his hips so those lean golden legs parted over him.

He tried to get a look under her dress, but still could not see from the angle.

She leaned down to him now, and suddenly her hand whipped across his face, a sharp crack shattering the still air as a similarly sharp pain jolted through his cheek.

“You like a real woman in charge, then?” she asked him.

She slapped him again, this time on the other cheek, making him jump. Jonah felt more than a little helpless—pulling on his unforgiving shackles now, he really could not do anything to defend himself.

“Well?” she slapped him again, fire in her eyes.

“Yes, I love it,” he said, his tone deferential, hoping to dissuade her from further violence.

“Miss,” she said. “You can call me ‘Miss’. I like that.”

“Yes, Miss.”

“Good boy.”

Now she stepped forward, legs parting further, feet either side of his head. Jonah felt some unspoken obligation to close his eyes, as though he wasn’t permitted to see what he so badly wanted to see.

But she said: “Open your eyes.”

He did so. His suspicion that she had removed her panties had been entirely correct. Looking up her slender thighs, he had the glorious view of her pussy.

“You want it?” she asked.

“Yes Miss.”

“Beg me for it.”

“Please, Miss. Please give it to me.”

Her legs parted as she sank down, her hands gripping her thighs, her muscles tense as she lowered her bare pussy towards his face, though hovering above it, rather than touching down.

He craned his neck to try to reach it, but for a moment or two she didn't give it to him, just waved it over his face. So pretty, with the little patch of jet-black hair above it, her lips glistening with her dew, her scent subtle, more like gentle

exotic soap than anything, though just a hint of her arousal.

"You are keen," she said, almost in awe, and now gave in to temptation, tucking her hot flesh down on his mouth.

He had a chance to breathe in her aroma, and taste her salty, tangy flavor, and then her hand gripped his head, pulled him to her.

"Come on, get in there," she insisted.

Her pubic hair tickled his nose as he tongued her and sucked gently on her lips.

"Oh yeah, right there," she breathed, pulling up her dress a little further.

Then she was leaning back, grinding her pussy over his face, spreading her wetness over him, using him. It was exhilarating—the way she sighed, the way she moaned at the pleasure he was giving to her, fucking his face.

"Hold that nose in my pussy, just like that," she said, pulling him into her.

The way she spoke so explicitly like that, telling him what she wanted—and that she wanted him to taste her—that was a huge thrill.

She pulled back, and looked down on him, taking in his red face, the mess she'd made of him with her wetness. "You like that?"

"Yes, Miss."

She slapped him again. It hurt. She might have a slender frame, but she had power in those muscles. It was shocking to Jonah—he wasn't used to this kind of force. "So what do you say?"

"Thank you, Miss," he said, hoping that was the right answer.

“Good,” she said, pulling her dress up so that the meagre amount of thin red material bunched around her waist, leaving her completely bare below, as though wearing only a tank top.

She made him beg for her pussy again, so that he was pleading with her as she wiggled her hips and shook it over him, asking him how badly he wanted it. She

leaned back and gripped his nipples, twisting harder than he’d ever want, though the sensations from her brutality seemed to get caught up in the thrill he felt from her wedging her pussy back down on his face.

The thrill as she fucked his face hard, moaning and screaming as he did his utmost to reward her for giving it to him.

“Suck it,” she ordered him, and he did as he as told, enveloping her clit in his hot mouth, pressing his tongue against it.

It wasn’t long until he felt her tense up, her body shuddering, thighs crushing his head as the energy of her orgasm swept through her. He felt the warm flood of her juices and licked for all he was worth, loving her savory tang.

“Well, that was a good start,” she said breathlessly, now dismounting. “I can see why you’re more than a one-date guy.”

He felt elated at pleasing her—what greater joy could there be than giving an orgasm to a beautiful woman?

He needed a moment or two to get his breath back, and perhaps stretch his limbs, which were gently aching from being locked in one place for a while.

She wasn’t letting him out of his shackles, however.

She returned shortly, and this time her hands went to his head, and he saw that she carried something black—a blindfold. Well, this was something else.

Entirely compliant for her, he lifted his head to allow her to slip the black cloth over it, and fasten it in place so that his eyes were completely covered.

“There,” she said.

He felt himself tremble, more in anticipation of something good happening than in fear—though he was a little nervous now that he could not see. What was going on? What was she doing?

He could still taste her flavor on his lips, and it made him wonder if it was true that old wives’ tale about your other senses becoming more keen when you lost one of them.

Feeling the mattress dip to one side of him as she climbed back onto the bed, and then the wondrous smooth texture of her skin as she slid over him again, he suspected there was something in the old maxim.

He guessed she was now facing his feet as she eased back into place, her pussy looming over his face so he could smell the dark spice of her arousal again.

“You want some?”

“Please, Miss.”

But this time, she was not indulging him, instead she was moving away down his body.

Jonah felt his chest fill with warmth in the hope that she would keep moving down his body, find temptation in the hardness of his cock as it strained so desperately for her touch.

She stood to turn around, and his hope only grew.

“I’m impressed—you really know how to please a woman, Robert,” she said.

He felt the strangest sensation, almost akin to a climax of his own, merely from the way she praised him. She hadn’t been kidding when she’d suggested he was submissive.

But then he felt the oxygen levels somehow reduce in that room as she added coldly: “Or should I say ‘Jonah’.”

He felt his erection soften, a coldness sweep through him, his skin crawling. Had he left some identifying object in a pocket? How had she found out his real name?

She suddenly jumped on him, like one of those costumed pro wrestlers in the ring, pounding him into the mattress. Her knees gripped his hips, crushing him fiercely until he was groaning, and not from pleasure.

“What—”

“I know all about you, Jonah Fielding,” she said, her voice suddenly full of

menace.

Her face dipped down by his, and then she was whispering in his ear: “You really think you were a match for me?”

He was confused, he didn’t understand what she was saying, but his mind was reaching for dark, dark possibilities. He kept expecting her to laugh, tell him what a scared little boy he was—yet she did not let up. She was silent, emotionless, and losing control of his thoughts, Jonah found the ice cold hand of fear closing round his heart.

“I don’t—” he stammered.

“You’re pathetic,” she spat.

He felt her knees now sink down on his arms, her weight pressing down to shut off the blood supply to his hands, the pain of her bone pressing into his flesh almost making him black out.

Then he felt something cold pressed against his chest—something cold and hard, and so terrifying.

Her hand closed around his neck, fingers surprisingly strong, crushing his vulnerable flesh, making him gag as she blocked his airway.

“I know you’re not a City boy, Jonah,” she said, and he felt his whole body going weak—perhaps she was disrupting the flow of blood going to his brain.

“You’re not just using that website to explore your sexuality, are you?”

“No, Miss,” he croaked, still acting the submissive, though he now strained against the handcuffs, trying to find some weakness that might allow him escape.

“Pathetic.”

He felt so stupid—that was the worst of it. As he felt her place the blade to his throat now, the tip so breathtakingly sharp, he thought how disappointed everyone would be with him. All those beautiful women he now had in his life—

Emma, Lily, Detective Mulray. They would all think him an imbecile. Death would come, and he would see for himself whether all that stuff about heaven was true or not. Perhaps there would be pain first—terrifying pain. But for now,

what he felt most, as a blush spread across his face, was pure unadulterated embarrassment.

Her hand let go of his neck, allowing him glorious oxygen once again. His relief was short-lived. He felt her fingers snake into his hair now, and then grip it tight.

It felt as though she was intent on pulling clumps of it from his head.

Then his hair was the least of his concerns as he felt the brutal sharp point press into him again.

And Kaia, whoever she was, drew the knife slowly across his throat.

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A romantic couple is shown in a close embrace on a dark-colored couch. The man, who has a beard and is shirtless, is leaning back against the woman. The woman is wearing a light pink short-sleeved shirt and a white ribbed skirt. Her hands are resting on the man's neck and shoulder. In the foreground, two glasses of red wine are visible on a dark surface, slightly out of focus. The overall atmosphere is intimate and sensual, with warm lighting.

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